

ECONOMIC INTELLIGENCE SERIES

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · June 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Raleigh	79.3
#2	A+	Atlanta	72.1
#3	A+	Hartford	69.1
#4	A+	Austin	68.5
#5	A	Charlotte	67.3
#6	A	Nashville	67.3
#7	A	Kansas City	66.2

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Jacksonville	18.9
#49	D	Minneapolis	23.6
#48	C-	Louisville	26.6
#47	C-	Riverside	30.8
#46	C-	Sacramento	31.4
#45	C-	Detroit	31.5
#44	C	Portland	32.4

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	10 cities
B+ / B / B-	22 cities
C+ / C / C-	16 cities
D	2 cities

Data sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) · Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED)
Unemployment, CLF Growth, Earnings, Employment, Weekly Hours sourced from BLS LAUS / SAE.
Building Permits from Census Bureau via FRED. Days on Market from Realtor.com / FRED.

Scoring methodology: percentile ranking across all 50 metros.
Full methodology: SCORING_README.md
Pipeline runs weekly via GitHub Actions.

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · June 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
1	Raleigh Raleigh-Cary	A+	79.3	3.0%	+4.1%	+2.0%	+1.7%	44 days
2	Atlanta Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	A+	72.1	3.3%	+5.2%	+0.2%	+1.4%	49 days
3	Hartford Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A+	69.1	2.7%	+1.5%	+1.9%	+2.8%	25 days
4	Austin Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A+	68.5	3.4%	+6.8%	+0.6%	+0.8%	51 days
5	Charlotte Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	A	67.3	3.7%	+2.1%	+1.1%	+1.1%	45 days
6	Nashville Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	A	67.3	2.9%	+5.8%	+0.3%	-0.4%	50 days
7	Kansas City Kansas City	A	66.2	3.9%	+8.0%	-0.0%	+0.4%	41 days
8	Cincinnati Cincinnati	A	65.5	3.7%	+4.2%	+0.3%	-0.4%	37 days
9	Dallas Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	A-	61.4	3.9%	+2.4%	+0.5%	+0.5%	46 days
10	San Jose San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	A-	59.2	3.9%	0.0%	+1.3%	-0.1%	28 days
11	Las Vegas Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	B+	58.9	5.4%	+5.6%	+2.0%	+2.4%	51 days
12	Birmingham Birmingham	B+	58.8	2.7%	-1.2%	+0.7%	+0.3%	52 days
13	Pittsburgh Pittsburgh	B+	58.2	4.0%	+6.3%	-0.4%	+1.2%	50 days
14	San Diego San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	B+	57.1	4.3%	+6.8%	+0.6%	-0.7%	38 days
15	Salt Lake City Salt Lake City-Murray	B+	57.1	3.9%	+4.3%	+1.3%	-0.7%	44 days
16	Columbus Columbus	B+	56.0	3.4%	+3.3%	+0.2%	-0.3%	36 days
17	Los Angeles Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B+	55.9	4.8%	+4.8%	+1.8%	-0.5%	46 days
18	Seattle Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B	54.4	4.9%	+7.4%	+0.1%	-0.8%	34 days
19	New York New York Newark-Jersey City	B	53.7	4.5%	+5.7%	+0.4%	+0.7%	41 days
20	Philadelphia Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	B	51.4	4.3%	-0.4%	+0.1%	+1.2%	36 days
21	San Francisco San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	B	51.2	4.0%	+6.7%	+0.3%	-1.4%	31 days
22	Houston Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	B	51.0	4.4%	+1.9%	+0.2%	+0.3%	48 days
23	Memphis Memphis	B	50.8	4.2%	+6.2%	-0.1%	-0.8%	54 days
24	Miami Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	B-	50.0	3.7%	+7.3%	-0.2%	+0.1%	77 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
25	Orlando Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	B-	49.9	4.4%	+2.8%	+1.1%	+1.1%	68 days
26	Tampa Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	B-	49.2	4.5%	+6.9%	+0.1%	+0.1%	67 days
27	Cleveland Cleveland	B-	49.0	3.4%	-0.6%	+0.6%	+1.8%	55 days
28	Oklahoma City Oklahoma City	B-	47.4	3.4%	+6.2%	-1.0%	-1.2%	51 days
29	Phoenix Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	B-	45.8	4.0%	+3.3%	+0.6%	-1.0%	57 days
30	Denver Denver-Aurora-Centennial	B-	45.1	3.7%	+0.7%	-0.2%	-2.3%	39 days
31	Chicago Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	B-	45.0	5.1%	+4.3%	+0.1%	-0.9%	34 days
32	Fresno Fresno	B-	44.9	8.9%	+4.2%	+1.7%	-0.2%	50 days
33	Providence Providence-Warwick	C+	43.9	4.3%	+3.5%	+0.6%	+1.7%	27 days
34	Virginia Beach Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	C+	43.7	3.9%	+6.8%	-0.7%	-0.4%	35 days
35	Grand Rapids Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	C+	42.9	4.0%	+3.0%	-0.1%	-4.5%	37 days
36	St. Louis St. Louis	C+	40.9	4.3%	+1.8%	-0.5%	+0.4%	42 days
37	San Antonio San Antonio-New Braunfels	C+	39.8	4.0%	+1.6%	+0.0%	-0.2%	53 days
38	Baltimore Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	C+	39.7	4.3%	+4.9%	-0.7%	+0.8%	32 days
39	Indianapolis Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	C	37.5	3.3%	+0.5%	-0.7%	-0.5%	41 days
40	Boston Boston-Cambridge-Newton	C	36.5	3.9%	+3.7%	-0.4%	+2.9%	25 days
41	Washington DC Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	C	36.1	4.1%	+4.8%	-2.9%	-2.1%	29 days
42	Milwaukee Milwaukee-Waukesha	C	33.3	4.2%	+1.5%	-0.9%	-0.0%	36 days
43	Richmond Richmond	C	33.0	3.7%	+3.0%	-0.5%	-0.3%	38 days
44	Portland Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	C	32.4	5.2%	+6.2%	-2.9%	-1.4%	47 days
45	Detroit Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	C-	31.5	5.3%	+2.3%	-0.9%	+0.9%	39 days
46	Sacramento Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	C-	31.4	4.7%	+1.1%	+0.4%	-0.6%	38 days
47	Riverside Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	C-	30.8	5.1%	+5.4%	+0.0%	-1.1%	54 days
48	Louisville Louisville-Jefferson County	C-	26.6	4.4%	+2.3%	-0.8%	-0.9%	38 days
49	Minneapolis Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	D	23.6	4.5%	+0.5%	-0.4%	-1.1%	33 days
50	Jacksonville Jacksonville	D	18.9	4.7%	+1.2%	-0.4%	-0.1%	58 days

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

A+

EXCELLENT

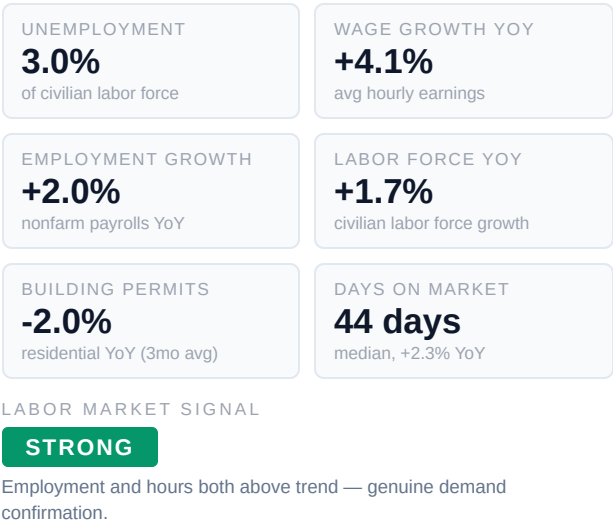
79.3th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking in the 79.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a composite score in the 98th percentile, and its low unemployment rate of 3.00%, ranking in the 90th percentile. The combination of strong employment growth and low unemployment signals a highly competitive job market.

Labor Demand

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has seen employment growth of +2.02% year-over-year, combined with a +1.762% deviation in weekly hours above its own 12-month trend. This signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth, indicating a strong and vibrant labor market. The labor demand composite score of 8.63 further reinforces this assessment, ranking in the top tier at the 98th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Raleigh-Cary stands at 3.00%, ranking in the 90th percentile, which indicates a very tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this area will face significant competition for talent, potentially driving up wage costs. With such a low unemployment rate, employers may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract and retain top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Raleigh-Cary is +4.09%, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, while workers are seeing some improvement in their purchasing power. However, the relatively modest wage growth may not be sufficient to keep pace with the cost of living in the area, potentially affecting worker affordability.

Cost of Living

Raleigh-Cary has a cost of living percentile rank of 84th, indicating that it is relatively more affordable compared to its peers, with a PSF of \$218/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$38.03/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.73. The fact that PSF is falling by -2.2% year-over-year further enhances the city's affordability. This makes the area an attractive destination for talent, as workers can enjoy a relatively lower cost of living without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Raleigh-Cary is growing at a rate of +1.72% year-over-year, ranking in the 90th percentile, which indicates that the workforce supply is expanding. This positive growth rate suggests that businesses will have access to a growing pool of potential

employees, making it easier to hire and staff their operations.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Raleigh-Cary has decreased by -2.03% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile. This decline in permits suggests that the housing supply may be tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Raleigh-Cary is 44 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.3%. This indicates a relatively competitive market, but one that is still accessible for workers relocating to the area. The rising days on market may signal a healthy normalization of the housing market, but it is essential to monitor this metric to ensure it does not become a barrier to workforce attraction.

Office Economy

Raleigh-Cary has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 98th, indicating a strong presence of jobs in professional and office sectors. This makes the area well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but potentially less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented economies.

The Raleigh-Cary metro area offers businesses a highly competitive and vibrant labor market, with a strong talent pool and relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the potential tightening of the housing supply, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce, making it essential to monitor the building permits and days on market metrics closely.

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

A+

EXCELLENT

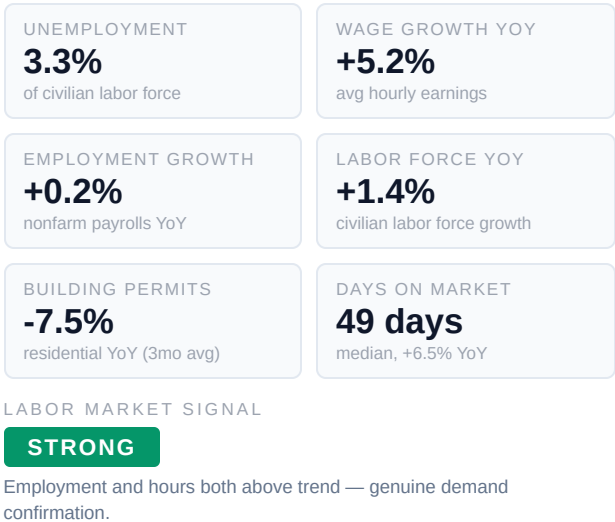
72.1th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking in the 72.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 5.82, and its low unemployment rate of 3.30%, which ranks in the 82nd percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with a tight labor market and genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Atlanta is +0.21% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating +1.222% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This indicates that the city is experiencing a real increase in labor demand, rather than just a shift in hours worked.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Atlanta is 3.30%, which is in the top tier and ranks in the 82nd percentile. This means that the labor market is tight, with relatively few workers available for hire. For a business trying to hire in this city, this implies that it may be challenging to find qualified candidates, and wage pressure may be higher as a result.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Atlanta is +5.22%, which is above average and ranks in the 66th percentile. This rate of wage growth is relatively fast, which implies that employer labor costs are rising. However, it also means that workers in the city have increasing purchasing power, which can be beneficial for businesses that rely on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Atlanta has a cost of living score that ranks in the 80th percentile, with a PSF of \$198/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$37.13/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.33. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. For talent attraction, this is a significant advantage, as businesses may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Atlanta is growing at a rate of +1.37% year-over-year, which is in the top tier and ranks in the 86th percentile. This means that the labor force supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire in the city. As the labor force grows, it can help to alleviate some of the pressure on wages and make it easier for companies to find qualified candidates.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Atlanta is decreasing at a rate of -7.48% year-over-year, which ranks near the median. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply may be tightening, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it more challenging for workers to relocate to the city.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Atlanta is currently 49 days, with a year-over-year increase of +6.5%. This means that homes are sitting on the market for a slightly longer period, which can make it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the market is still relatively competitive, and businesses may need to consider this when making relocation decisions.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Atlanta is 3.36, which ranks in the 78th percentile. This indicates that the city has a deep talent pool in these sectors, making it well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ spaces. However, it may be less suitable for businesses that require a large number of industrial or logistics workers.

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, low unemployment, and relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to consider is the tightening housing supply, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it more challenging for workers to relocate to the city.

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

A+

EXCELLENT

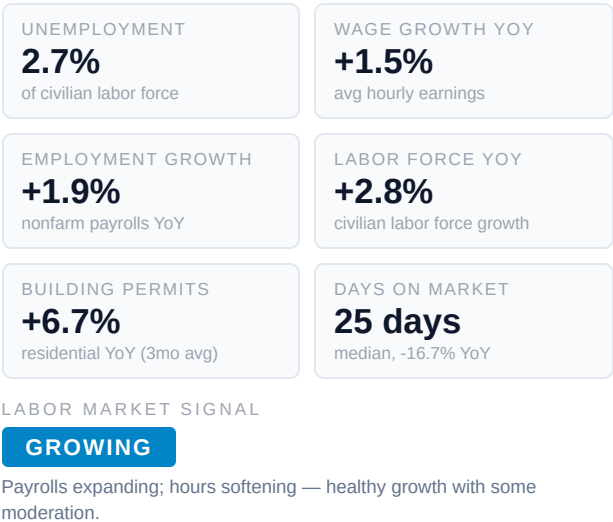
69.1th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking it at the 69.1th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 2.70% and its strong labor demand composite score of 6.66, which ranks in the 90th percentile. The combination of a high employment growth rate and low unemployment suggests a city with genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is +1.88% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.272% below the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs at a rate above the national average. The labor demand composite score of 6.66, ranking in the 90th percentile, further supports this conclusion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 2.70%, ranking in the 98th percentile, indicating an extremely tight labor market. This means that businesses may face significant challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is very small. As a result, wage pressure is likely to be high, making it essential for companies to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is +1.48%, ranking in the 18th percentile, indicating relatively slow wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power may be limited. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have the same level of disposable income as in other cities.

Cost of Living

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has a cost of living score ranking in the 63rd percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$254/sqft to \$39.73/hr, or 6.39 above average. While not extremely affordable, the city's cost of living is relatively moderate, which can be a talent attraction advantage without requiring significant wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling -1.6% year-over-year relative to wages also contributes to the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is growing at a rate of +2.77% year-over-year, ranking in the 96th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding rapidly, which is a significant advantage for businesses looking to hire. The growing labor force provides a larger pool of potential employees, making it easier for companies to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is increasing by +6.72% year-over-year, ranking in the 60th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. As a result, the city is likely to remain an attractive location for workers and businesses alike.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 25 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -16.7%. This indicates a highly competitive market, where homes are selling quickly. For workers relocating to this city, the fast-paced market may make it challenging to find a home, potentially requiring them to act quickly or face rising prices.

Office Economy

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has an office economy score ranking in the 38th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep pool of specialized office workers, such as industrial or logistics companies. However, it may not be the ideal location for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely on a highly skilled and abundant office workforce.

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, low unemployment, and moderate cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the highly competitive housing market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing, potentially impacting a company's ability to attract and retain top talent.

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

A+

EXCELLENT

68.5th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 68.5th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier wage growth of 6.75% year-over-year and its highly affordable cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 6.41, ranking it in the 92nd percentile. These metrics signal a strong and attractive labor market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 0.63% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.498% from the city's own trend. This combination signals a near median labor demand, indicating neither strong expansion nor contraction. The labor demand composite score of 4.68 further supports this assessment, suggesting a stable but not exceptionally strong job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 3.40%, ranking it in the 78th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with relatively low unemployment. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the market has less slack, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 6.75%, ranking it in the 86th percentile, indicating fast and strong wage growth. This implies that employer labor costs are rising, but workers also have increasing purchasing power. The rapid wage growth may attract high-skilled workers but also increases the cost burden for businesses.

Cost of Living

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos has a cost of living percentile rank of 92, indicating that it is highly affordable relative to its peers. The PSF to wages ratio of 6.41, with PSF decreasing by 7.7% year-over-year, suggests that the city offers a competitive advantage in talent attraction without requiring significant wage premiums. This affordability is a major draw for businesses and workers alike.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is growing at a rate of 0.81% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth suggests that the city has a increasing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is -19.65%, indicating a tightening housing supply. This decline in permits suggests that the city may face future affordability challenges and workforce accommodation constraints, potentially impacting its attractiveness to businesses and workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of 15.9%, ranking it in the 86th percentile. This indicates a slower market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. The rising days on market suggests a healthy normalization of the housing market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos has a deep professional talent pool, ranking in the 92nd percentile, making it well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. The city's strong office economy is a major advantage for businesses requiring specialized knowledge workers, but it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, affordable cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for businesses in the knowledge economy. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may impact future affordability and workforce accommodation, potentially eroding the city's competitive advantage.

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

A

VERY GOOD

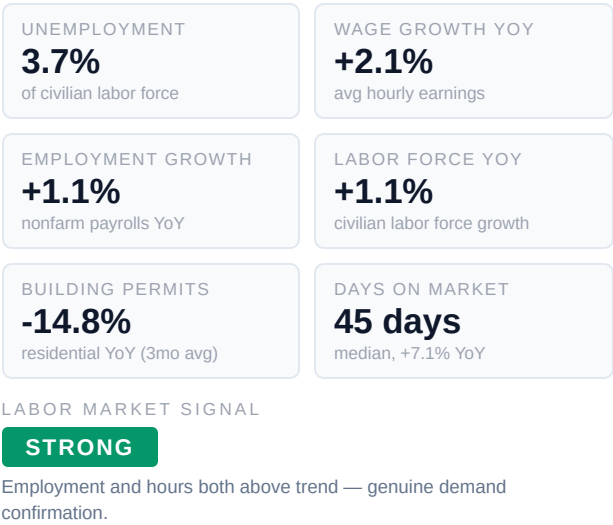
67.3th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 67.3th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and a deep professional talent pool being the two metrics that most define its current economic character, scoring 88th percentile in labor demand composite and 82nd percentile in office/professional worker share. The labor demand composite score of 6.66, driven by a 1.08% employment growth rate and a 0.846% weekly hours deviation above trend, signals genuine demand expansion. This combination of metrics suggests a city with a strong and growing economy.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.08% and weekly hours deviation of 0.846% above trend indicate a labor market with genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This signals that the city is experiencing a surge in economic activity, with businesses hiring more workers and existing workers putting in more hours. The labor demand composite score of 6.66 further reinforces this notion, ranking in the top tier at 88th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.70% is relatively low, ranking above average at 76th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding and hiring qualified workers, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. As a result, wage pressure is likely to be higher in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 2.06% is below average, ranking at 28th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in other cities. While this may be beneficial for employers, it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing as quickly as it could be.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of \$220/sqft and an earnings ratio of \$37.49/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.87, is above average in terms of affordability, ranking at 76th percentile. The fact that PSF is falling by 1.8% YoY relative to wages further enhances the city's affordability. This makes it an attractive location for talent, as workers can afford a higher quality of life without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 1.13% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests that there will be a growing pool of potential workers to draw from. With a rank of 78th percentile, the city's labor force growth is above average, providing a favorable environment for hiring.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -14.84%, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This suggests that the city may face future affordability challenges and workforce accommodation constraints, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. With a rank of 28th percentile, the city's building permits growth is below average, signaling a potential risk for businesses relying on a growing and affordable workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 45 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.1%, indicating a slowing market. This means that workers relocating to the city may find it slightly easier to find a home, as the market is becoming less competitive. However, with a rank of 76th percentile, the city's days on market is still relatively fast, suggesting that the market remains relatively hot.

Office Economy

The city's professional talent pool is deep, ranking in the top tier at 82nd percentile, making it an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. The city's strong office economy suggests that it is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge workers, but may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area offers businesses a strong and growing economy, with a deep professional talent pool and an affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability challenges and workforce accommodation constraints, potentially limiting the city's ability to attract and retain talent.

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

A

VERY GOOD

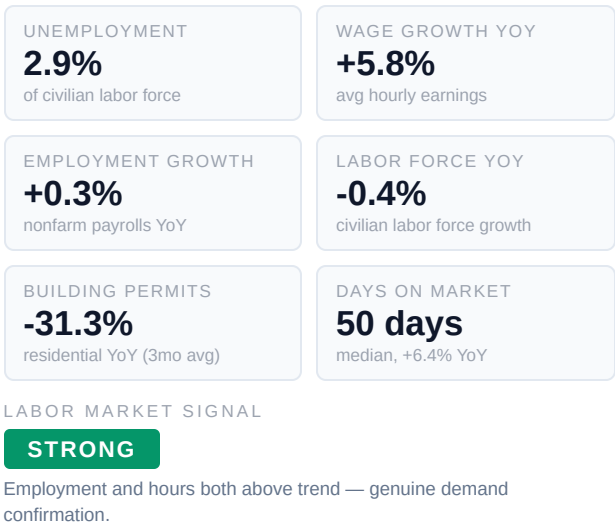
67.3th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 67.3th percentile among 50 US metros, with its labor demand and unemployment rate being the two metrics that most define its current economic character, at 82nd and 88th percentiles, respectively. The city's strong labor demand, combined with low unemployment, signals a competitive job market with genuine demand expansion. With an employment growth rate of 0.28% and weekly hours 1.321% above trend, Nashville's economy is experiencing a period of sustained growth.

Labor Demand

Nashville's labor demand composite score is 6.01, indicating a top-tier performance, with employment growth of 0.28% and weekly hours 1.321% above trend, signaling genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, indicating a strong and growing economy. The labor market is characterized by increasing demand, with no signs of contraction or survivor squeeze.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Nashville is 2.90%, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with little slack. This low unemployment rate means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight labor market also puts upward pressure on wages, as workers have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Nashville is 5.81% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 74th percentile, indicating moderate to fast wage growth. This rate of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing, which can have positive effects on local consumer demand. As wages continue to grow, businesses may need to adjust their pricing strategies to maintain profitability.

Cost of Living

Nashville's cost of living is relatively affordable, with a percentile rank of 65th, and a price-to-salary ratio of \$262/sqft to \$35.91/hr, or 7.30, which is above average. The fact that the price per square foot is falling by 1.1% year-over-year relative to wages makes the city more attractive for talent, as workers can afford a higher quality of life without requiring significant wage premiums. This affordability advantage can be a major draw for businesses looking to attract and retain top talent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Nashville is shrinking, with a year-over-year growth rate of -0.40%, ranking below average at the 38th percentile. This contraction in the labor force supply means that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. As the labor force continues to shrink, businesses may need to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain talent.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Nashville is falling sharply, with a year-over-year change of -31.30%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which can lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing, making it more challenging for workers to relocate to the city. The lack of new housing supply can also put upward pressure on rents and home prices.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Nashville is 50 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.4%, ranking above average at the 60th percentile. This indicates a slowing market, where homes are taking longer to sell, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, the relatively fast pace of sales still suggests a competitive market, and workers may need to act quickly to secure housing.

Office Economy

Nashville's professional and office worker share is 3.74, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile, indicating a deep and talented pool of knowledge-economy workers. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require specialized talent. However, the city may be less suited for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors, which require a different type of workforce.

In conclusion, Nashville offers businesses a strong and growing economy, with a talented and deep pool of knowledge-economy workers, making it an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors. However, the city's tight labor market and shrinking labor force supply pose significant risks and constraints, and businesses should factor in the potential challenges of hiring and retaining talent in this competitive market.

Kansas City

Kansas City

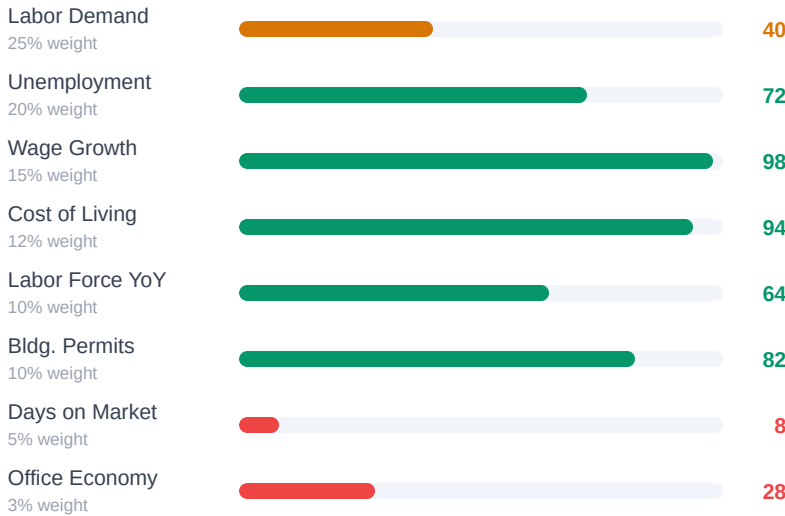
A

VERY GOOD

66.2th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.9%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+8.0%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.0%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+0.4%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+34.5%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

41 days

median, -12.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City earns an overall grade of A, ranking in the 66.2th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its top-tier wage growth and cost of living. The city's economic character is defined by its exceptional wage growth of 7.97% year-over-year and a highly affordable cost of living, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$199/sqft to \$36.17/hr, ranking in the 94th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with strong labor market dynamics and attractive living costs.

Labor Demand

Kansas City's labor demand composite score is 3.84, near the median, driven by a slight decline in employment growth of -0.03% year-over-year and a modest increase in weekly hours of 0.421% above its own trend. This combination signals a relatively stable labor market, neither expanding nor contracting significantly. The hours deviation above trend during a period of slight job loss may indicate a mild survivor squeeze, where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate is 3.90%, ranking in the 72nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with some slack. This means that while it may be slightly harder for businesses to hire, the market is not overly competitive, and wage pressure is moderate. Businesses trying to hire in Kansas City may need to offer competitive wages, but the talent pool is still accessible.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 7.97%, Kansas City experiences fast and rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is beneficial for worker purchasing power, as employees see significant increases in their earnings. However, this may pose a challenge for businesses looking to maintain a flat cost environment.

Cost of Living

Kansas City's cost of living is highly affordable, ranking in the 94th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$199/sqft to \$36.17/hr. This affordability advantage means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs. The city's attractive cost of living is a major talent attraction advantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Kansas City is growing at a rate of 0.37% year-over-year, indicating a modest expansion of the workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city's hiring capacity is increasing, making it easier for businesses to find and recruit talent.

Building Permits

The city has seen a significant increase in residential building permits, with a year-over-year change of 34.49%, ranking in the 82nd percentile. This surge in permits signals an expansion of future housing supply, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

Homes in Kansas City are currently selling at a median of 41 days on market, with a year-over-year decrease of 12.8%. This fast-paced market makes it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing, as homes are selling quickly.

Office Economy

Kansas City's professional and office worker share is below average, ranking in the 28th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. The city is less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting, but may be more accommodating to industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Kansas City offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, affordable living costs, and a modestly expanding labor force, making it an attractive location for talent attraction and retention. However, the city's relatively shallow professional talent pool and fast-paced housing market may pose challenges for businesses requiring specialized office workers or relocating employees, and these factors should be carefully considered in any location decision.

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

A

VERY GOOD

65.5th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati earns an overall grade of A, ranking in the 65.5th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low unemployment rate of 3.70% and a cost of living score that ranks in the 88th percentile, indicating a highly affordable market. The city's labor demand composite score is near median, at 4.60, reflecting a balance between employment growth and hours worked. With a strong showing in affordability and a tight labor market, Cincinnati presents an attractive location for businesses looking to balance labor costs and talent attraction.

Labor Demand

Cincinnati's employment growth rate is +0.30% year-over-year, combined with a -0.124% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, signaling a near-neutral labor demand environment that neither strongly expands nor contracts. This balance suggests that while there is some job growth, it is not significantly outpacing the city's baseline hours worked, indicating a stable but not booming labor market. The combination does not clearly indicate genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cincinnati is 3.70%, ranking in the 92nd percentile, which means the labor market is tight, with low unemployment. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. For a business trying to hire in Cincinnati, this means being prepared to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Cincinnati is +4.25% year-over-year, placing it near the median in terms of wage growth rates. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate, while workers see an increase in their purchasing power. The implication is a relatively stable labor cost environment that supports worker consumption without overly pressuring business margins.

Cost of Living

Cincinnati's cost of living, with a PSF of \$192/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$35.36, resulting in a ratio of 5.43, ranks in the 88th percentile, indicating a highly affordable city relative to its peers. The fact that PSF is decreasing by -0.5% year-over-year further enhances the city's affordability. This high affordability score means that Cincinnati has a significant talent attraction advantage, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without necessitating wage premiums from employers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cincinnati is growing at a rate of -0.39% year-over-year, indicating a slight contraction in the labor pool. This negative growth rate suggests that the supply of potential workers is shrinking, which could pose a structural headwind for businesses looking to hire, potentially limiting their capacity to expand or fill vacancies.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Cincinnati are increasing by +19.15% year-over-year, signaling an expansion in housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that developer confidence is strong, and the future housing supply is likely to improve, which should help maintain or improve affordability and support the attraction and retention of workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Cincinnati is 37 days, with an 8.8% year-over-year increase, ranking in the 84th percentile. This indicates a slower market where homes are sitting longer before being sold, which can be beneficial for relocating workers, providing them with more time to find a suitable home and making the city more accessible for talent attraction.

Office Economy

Cincinnati's share of jobs in professional and office sectors places it near the median, ranking in the 40th percentile. This suggests that while the city has a notable professional talent pool, it is not as deep as in other metros, making it more suited for businesses that do not solely rely on tech, finance, or consulting talent, but can still support a variety of industries with its balanced economy.

In conclusion, Cincinnati offers businesses a unique blend of affordability, a tight labor market, and moderate wage growth, making it an attractive location for those seeking to balance labor costs with talent attraction. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the slight contraction in the labor force, which could limit hiring capacity and business expansion plans, necessitating strategic workforce planning and potentially leveraging the city's affordability to attract talent from other regions.

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

A-

GOOD

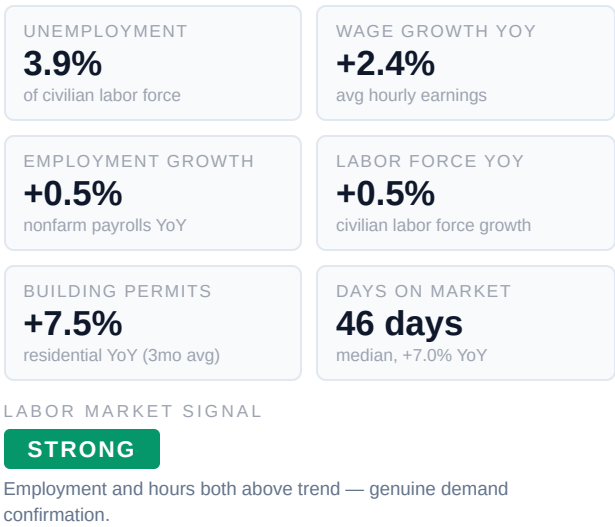
61.4th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 61.4th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score at the 64th percentile, and its high office economy ranking at the 96th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool in professional sectors. The labor demand is driven by a combination of employment growth and hours worked above trend, signaling genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has seen employment growth of 0.51% year-over-year, combined with weekly hours 0.186% above its own 12-month trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The labor demand composite score of 5.20 is at the 64th percentile, indicating a strong job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 3.90%, ranking at the 62nd percentile, which indicates a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 2.44%, which is below average, ranking at the 34th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly. This may be a concern for businesses looking to attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is relatively affordable, with a percentile rank of 69th, driven by a PSF of \$203/sqft, which is decreasing by 1.5% year-over-year, and an average hourly earnings of \$37.61/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.40. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as workers may not require wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is growing at a rate of 0.52% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that businesses will have a larger pool of potential workers to hire from, making it easier to find and attract talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington has increased by 7.46% year-over-year, indicating an expansion of future housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that housing affordability may improve, and the city may become more attractive to relocating workers, as the supply of housing is increasing to meet demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is currently 46 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.0%, ranking at the 74th percentile. This slower market means that relocating workers may have an easier time finding a home, as properties are sitting on the market for a longer period, giving them more time to make a decision.

Office Economy

The office economy in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is deep, with a professional and office worker share ranking at the 96th percentile, indicating a strong talent pool in sectors such as tech, finance, and consulting. This city is well-suited for businesses in these industries, but may not be as attractive for companies in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area offers businesses a strong labor market, a deep talent pool in professional sectors, and an affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand or relocate. However, the moderate wage growth rate and relatively tight labor market may pose challenges for businesses trying to attract and retain top talent, and decision-makers should factor in the potential need for competitive wages to stay ahead in this market.

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

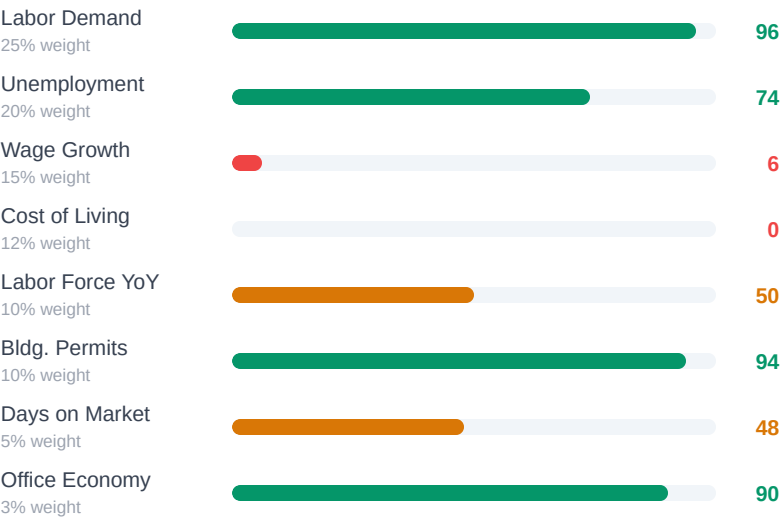
A-

GOOD

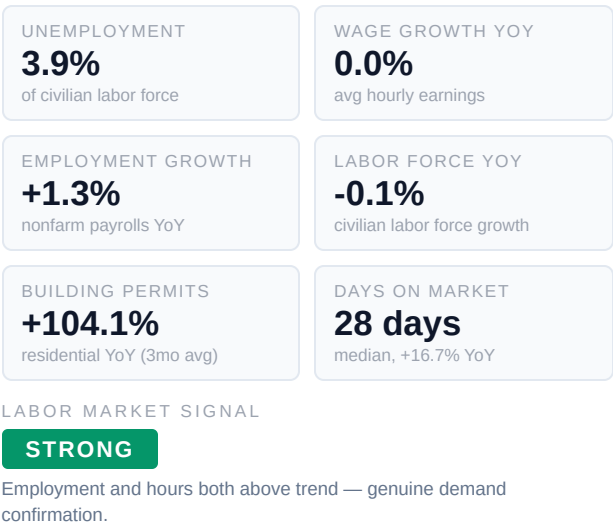
59.2th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 59.2th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier labor demand, with a composite score of 7.35, and its extremely low affordability, with a cost of living ratio of 15.63. The labor demand and cost of living metrics are crucial in understanding the city's economic landscape, with the 96th percentile labor demand score and 0th percentile cost of living score indicating a highly competitive job market and extremely high cost of living.

Labor Demand

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an employment growth rate of 1.32% and a weekly hours deviation of 1.205% above its own trend, signaling genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing a strong increase in jobs and hours worked, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The top-tier labor demand composite score of 7.35 further reinforces this notion, with the city ranking at the 96th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 3.90%, which is relatively low and corresponds to an above-average percentile rank of 74th. This tight labor market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have more bargaining power in the job market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 0.00%, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not increasing rapidly, but it also implies that workers may not have strong bargaining power. The bottom-tier percentile rank of 6th further emphasizes the slow wage growth in the city.

Cost of Living

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has a cost of living ratio of 15.63, with a price per square foot of \$846 and average hourly earnings of \$54.13. The city's cost of living percentile rank is 0th, indicating that it is extremely expensive relative to its peers. This means that the city is at a significant disadvantage in terms of talent attraction, as businesses may need to offer substantial wage premiums to compensate for the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is growing at a rate of -0.11% year-over-year, indicating a slight contraction in the labor pool. This near-median growth rate suggests that the city's workforce supply is not expanding rapidly, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring. The 50th percentile rank further emphasizes the moderate labor force growth in the city.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has increased by 104.08% year-over-year, indicating a significant expansion in housing supply. This top-tier growth rate suggests that developer confidence is high, and the city's future housing supply is likely to improve, which could lead to increased affordability and a more attractive environment for workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 28 days, with a year-over-year increase of 16.7%. This near-median percentile rank of 48th indicates that the housing market is relatively balanced, neither extremely competitive nor extremely slow. For workers relocating to the city, this means that the housing market is moderately accessible, but not overly competitive.

Office Economy

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share of 3.88 and a percentile rank of 90th. This suggests that the city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suitable for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area offers businesses a highly competitive and growing economy, with a strong labor demand and expanding housing supply. However, the city's extremely high cost of living and slow wage growth pose significant challenges for talent attraction and retention, and businesses should carefully consider these factors when making location decisions. The high cost of living, in particular, is a major constraint that decision-makers should factor in, as it may require substantial wage premiums to attract and retain top talent.

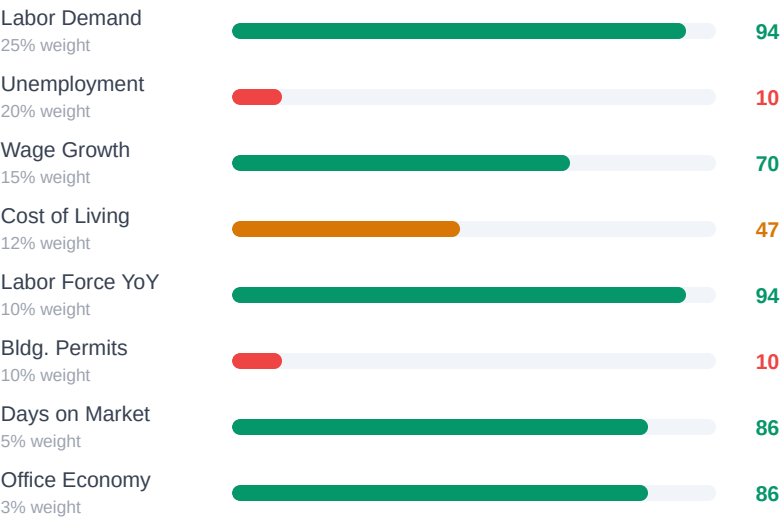
Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

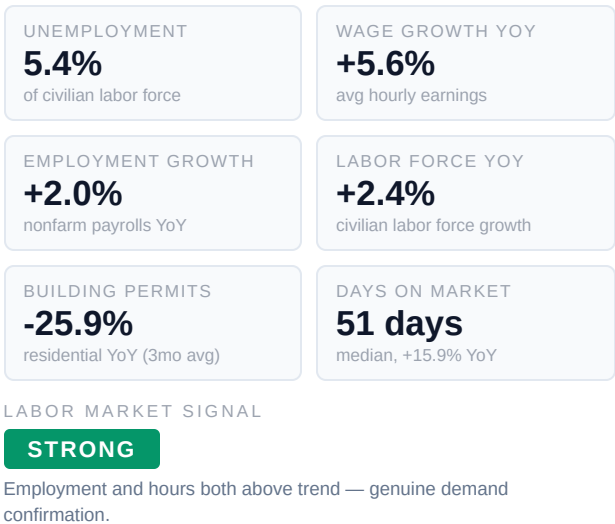
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
58.9th percentile
Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 58.9th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 94th percentile, and its low unemployment rate, which stands at 5.40% and ranks at the 10th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a highly competitive job market with genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is +2.04% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.024%, indicating a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a period of job growth, with hours worked above the trend, suggesting that businesses are hiring and workers are in high demand. The labor demand composite score of 7.18 further reinforces this assessment, ranking the city at the 94th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is 5.40%, which is relatively high and ranks at the 10th percentile, indicating a market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but the local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate. However, the strong labor demand suggests that the city is still experiencing job growth, which could lead to a tightening of the labor market in the future.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is +5.63%, which is above average and ranks at the 70th percentile. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing. The moderate wage growth rate indicates a relatively healthy labor market, where workers have some bargaining power, but employers are not facing extreme cost pressures.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is near the median, with a percentile rank of 47th, and a price-to-salary ratio of \$265/sqft to \$33.16/hr, or 7.99. The fact that the PSF is falling by -2.2% year-over-year is a key driver of the city's affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage, as businesses may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is growing at a rate of +2.43% year-over-year, which is a top-tier growth rate ranking at the 94th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire workers. The growing labor force suggests that the city has a strong pipeline of potential employees, which could support future business growth.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas has decreased by -25.89% year-over-year, which is a significant decline and ranks at the 10th percentile. This suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the city. The sharp decline in building permits is a concern for businesses that rely on a steady supply of housing for their employees.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is 51 days, which is increasing by +15.9% year-over-year, ranking at the 86th percentile. This suggests that the housing market is slowing down, making it more accessible for workers to relocate to the city. However, the relatively fast days on market indicates that the city is still experiencing a competitive housing market, which could be a challenge for relocating workers.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is 3.66, which ranks at the 86th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool. This suggests that the city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of professional workers. However, the city may be less suited for businesses that require a large industrial or logistics workforce.

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a relatively affordable cost of living, and a deep talent pool of professional workers. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the tightening housing supply, which could lead to future affordability issues and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the city.

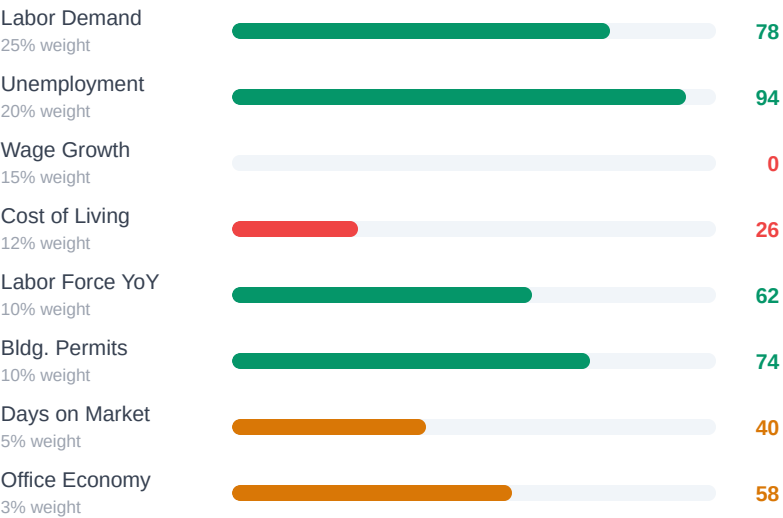
Birmingham

Birmingham

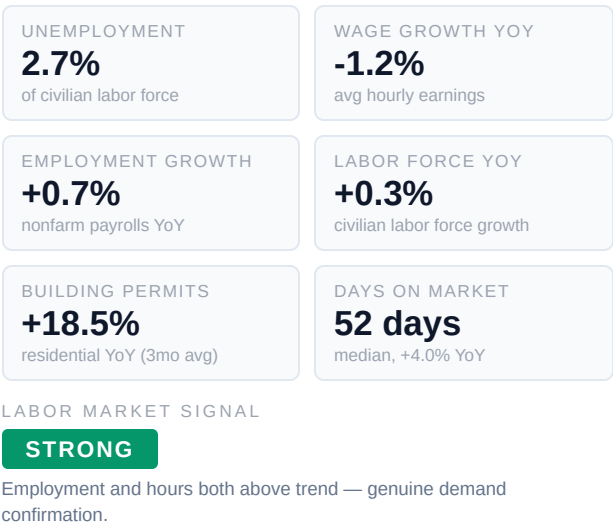
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
58.8th percentile
Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 58.8th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 78th percentile, and its extremely low unemployment rate of 2.70%, ranking it in the 94th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with a thriving job market and intense competition for labor.

Labor Demand

Birmingham's employment growth rate of +0.66% year-over-year, combined with a +0.680% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. This indicates that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, suggesting a strong and growing economy. The combination of these metrics points to a labor market where businesses are actively hiring and workers are in high demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Birmingham is 2.70%, ranking it in the 94th percentile, indicating an extremely tight labor market. This means that there is very little slack in the market, making it challenging for businesses to find and hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Birmingham is -1.22%, ranking it in the 0th percentile, indicating stagnant or even declining wages. This suggests that labor costs for employers are not increasing, but it also means that workers may have limited bargaining power and purchasing power. The stagnant wage growth may be a concern for businesses relying on a highly skilled and motivated workforce.

Cost of Living

Birmingham's cost of living, with a PSF of \$161/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$32.72/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.92, ranks it in the 26th percentile, indicating a relatively expensive city. However, the fact that the PSF is increasing by 0.6% year-over-year suggests that the city may become even less affordable in the future. This could make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Birmingham is growing at a rate of +0.35% year-over-year, ranking it in the 62nd percentile, indicating a moderate expansion of the workforce. This suggests that the supply of labor is increasing, which could help businesses meet their hiring needs. However, the relatively slow growth rate may not be enough to keep up with the demand for labor in the city's thriving job market.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Birmingham is increasing by +18.48% year-over-year, ranking it in the 74th percentile, indicating a significant expansion of the housing supply. This suggests that the city is experiencing an increase in developer confidence, which could lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce. The growing housing supply could help alleviate some of the pressure on the labor market.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Birmingham is 52 days, with a year-over-year increase of +4.0%, ranking it in the 40th percentile. This suggests that the housing market is relatively balanced, neither extremely competitive nor extremely slow. For workers relocating to the city, this means that they may have a moderate amount of time to find a home, but the market is not so slow that it becomes easy to find a property.

Office Economy

Birmingham's professional and office worker share ranks it in the 58th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and non-professional workers, but may not be the best fit for companies that require a highly specialized or technical workforce. The city's office economy is likely to support businesses in industries such as finance, consulting, and healthcare, but may not be as attractive to tech or logistics companies.

In conclusion, Birmingham offers businesses a thriving job market with strong labor demand and a highly competitive environment. However, the city's extremely low unemployment rate and stagnant wage growth may pose challenges for businesses trying to attract and retain top talent. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for upward pressure on wages and the need to offer competitive compensation packages to attract the best workers.

Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
58.2th percentile
Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		34
Unemployment 20% weight		66
Wage Growth 15% weight		82
Cost of Living 12% weight		57
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		82
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		48
Days on Market 5% weight		60
Office Economy 3% weight		46

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 4.0%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +6.3%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY -0.4%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth +1.2%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -4.0%	DAYS ON MARKET median, +6.4% YoY 50 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh earns an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 58.2th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.34%, and its labor force growth, which is expanding at a rate of 1.20% per year. These metrics suggest a city with a growing workforce and rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

Pittsburgh's employment growth rate is -0.43% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from trend by -0.173%, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 3.70, which ranks below average at the 34th percentile. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The city's labor market is not adding jobs at a significant rate, which may indicate a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Pittsburgh is 4.00%, which ranks above average at the 66th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight labor market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

Pittsburgh's year-over-year wage growth rate is 6.34%, which ranks at the 82nd percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This rapid increase in wages suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing. Businesses should be prepared for higher labor costs, but may also benefit from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

Pittsburgh's cost of living, with a PSF of \$171/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$33.65/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.08, ranks near the median at the 57th percentile. This means that the city is neither extremely affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. The relatively neutral cost of living means that businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent, but may not have a major advantage in this regard either.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Pittsburgh is growing at a rate of 1.20% year-over-year, which ranks at the 82nd percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth in the labor force suggests that businesses may have an easier time hiring, as the pool of available workers is increasing. The expanding labor force also provides a foundation for future economic growth.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Pittsburgh is decreasing at a rate of -4.03% year-over-year, which ranks near the median at the 48th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply may be tightening, which could lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future. Businesses should be aware of the potential for future workforce accommodation challenges.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Pittsburgh is 50 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.4%, which ranks above average at the 60th percentile. This means that the housing market is slowing down, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. The slower market may provide businesses with an advantage in attracting talent, as workers may have an easier time finding housing.

Office Economy

Pittsburgh's professional and office worker share ranks near the median at the 46th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and industrial skills, but may not be the top choice for businesses that require a highly specialized or knowledge-intensive workforce.

In conclusion, Pittsburgh offers businesses a growing workforce and rising labor costs, with a relatively tight labor market and fast wage growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the potential for future workforce accommodation challenges due to a tightening housing supply, which could lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing.

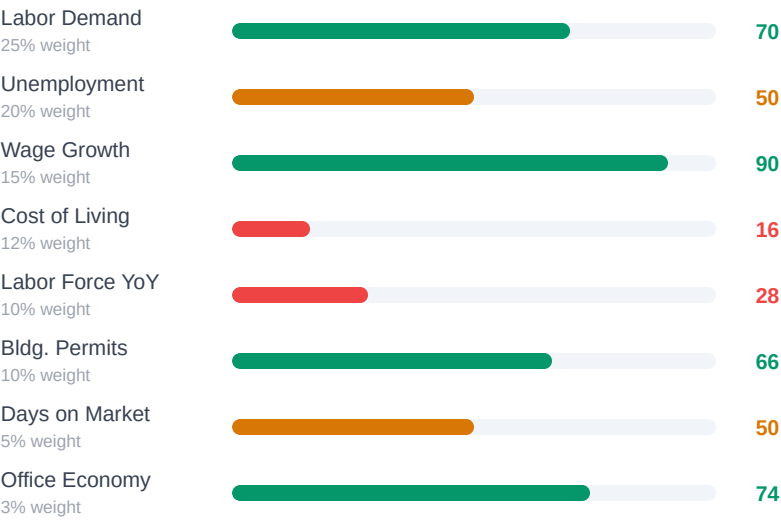
San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

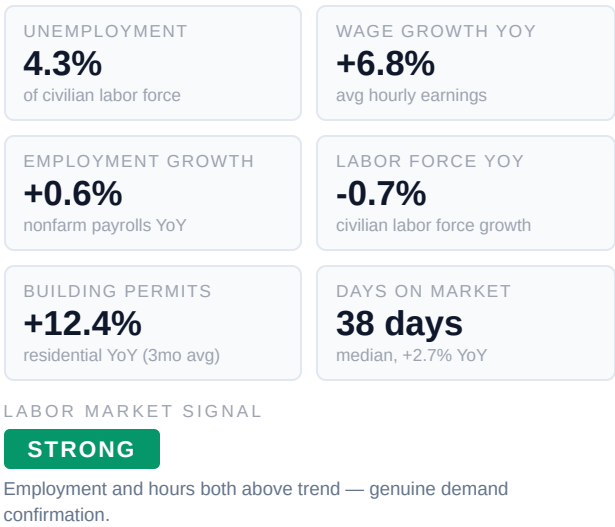
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
57.1th percentile
Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 57.1th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.85%, and its above-average labor demand, driven by employment growth of 0.64% and weekly hours 0.303% above trend. These metrics signal a city with a robust and expanding economy.

Labor Demand

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has seen employment growth of 0.64% and weekly hours 0.303% above its own 12-month trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 5.50, which ranks at the 70th percentile. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours worked are increasing. This is a positive indicator for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad stands at 4.30%, ranking at the 50th percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to cities with tighter labor markets. However, this also means that local consumer demand may not be as strong as in areas with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 6.85%, San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad ranks at the 90th percentile, indicating fast and strong wage growth. This implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power, which can benefit local businesses. This strong wage growth is a double-edged sword, offering benefits for workers but potential challenges for employers looking to manage labor costs.

Cost of Living

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a cost of living score that ranks at the 16th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$605/sqft to \$43.04/hr, or 14.06. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, as a lower percentile rank suggests higher costs. The fact that PSF is falling by 4.1% year-over-year slightly mitigates this, but overall, the high cost of living may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract talent, potentially offsetting some of the benefits of the area's strong economy.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has contracted by 0.65% year-over-year, ranking at the 28th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is shrinking, which could pose a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion in the area. A contracting labor force can limit the pool of potential employees, making it more challenging for businesses to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has increased by 12.45% year-over-year, ranking at the 66th percentile. This rise in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. An increase in housing supply can help mitigate some of the pressures from a high cost of living, making the area more attractive for workers and businesses alike.

Days on Market

Homes in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad currently sit on the market for a median of 38 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.7%. This ranks at the 50th percentile, indicating a near-median pace of home sales. For workers relocating to this city, the market is neither extremely competitive nor overly accessible, offering a relatively balanced environment for homebuyers.

Office Economy

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has an office economy score that ranks at the 74th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers indicating a deep talent pool. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that rely on specialized knowledge workers. Conversely, it may be less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area offers businesses a strong economy with expanding labor demand and high wage growth, making it an attractive location for companies looking to tap into a skilled and growing workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the relatively high cost of living, which may necessitate wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially offsetting some of the area's economic advantages.

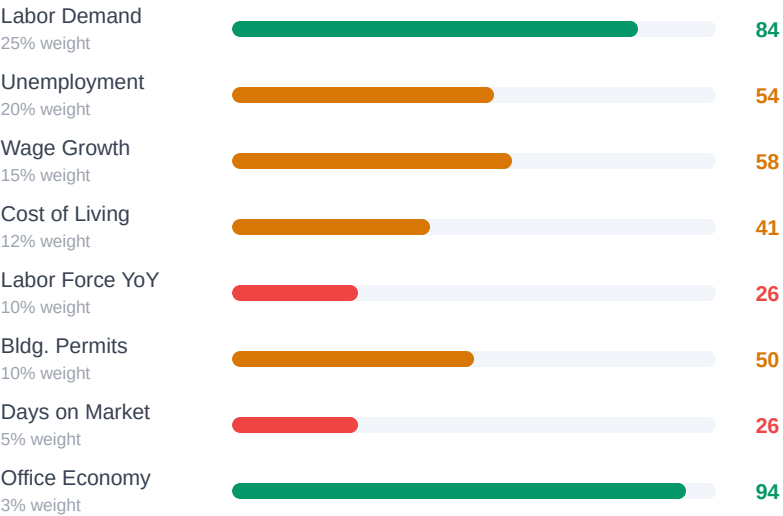
Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

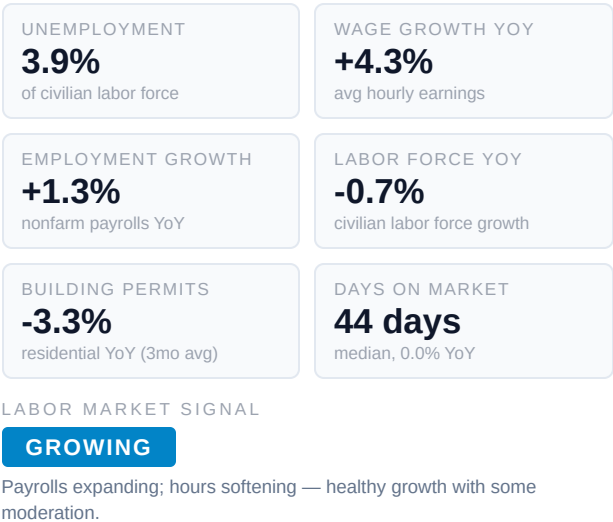
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
57.1th percentile
Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 57.1th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 84th percentile, and its deep professional talent pool, ranking in the 94th percentile for office and professional worker share. The labor demand is driven by a 1.33% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -0.047% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has a labor demand composite score of 6.12, ranking in the top tier at the 84th percentile, driven by a 1.33% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -0.047% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are only slightly below trend during a period of job growth. The strong labor demand indicates a competitive job market with many opportunities for workers.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Salt Lake City-Murray is 3.90%, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile. This rate indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. As a result, businesses may face some wage pressure when trying to attract and retain top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Salt Lake City-Murray is 4.31%, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers are experiencing an increase in purchasing power, which can contribute to a stronger local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Salt Lake City-Murray has a cost of living ratio of \$265/sqft to \$39.12/hr, ranking near the median at the 41st percentile. This means that the city is neither extremely affordable nor extremely expensive relative to its peers. However, the fact that the PSF is not falling YoY means that affordability is not improving. As a result, businesses may need to consider wage premiums to attract talent to this city without a significant cost-of-living advantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Salt Lake City-Murray is shrinking at a rate of -0.68% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 26th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers to fill open positions.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Salt Lake City-Murray has decreased by 3.28% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is not expanding rapidly, which may lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Salt Lake City-Murray is 44 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing. However, the stable days on market suggests that the market is not becoming more competitive over time.

Office Economy

Salt Lake City-Murray has a deep professional talent pool, with an office and professional worker share ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that require specialized knowledge-economy talent. In contrast, the city may be less suitable for businesses with primarily industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force supply, which poses a structural challenge for hiring and may require businesses to adapt their recruitment strategies to attract and retain top talent in this competitive market.

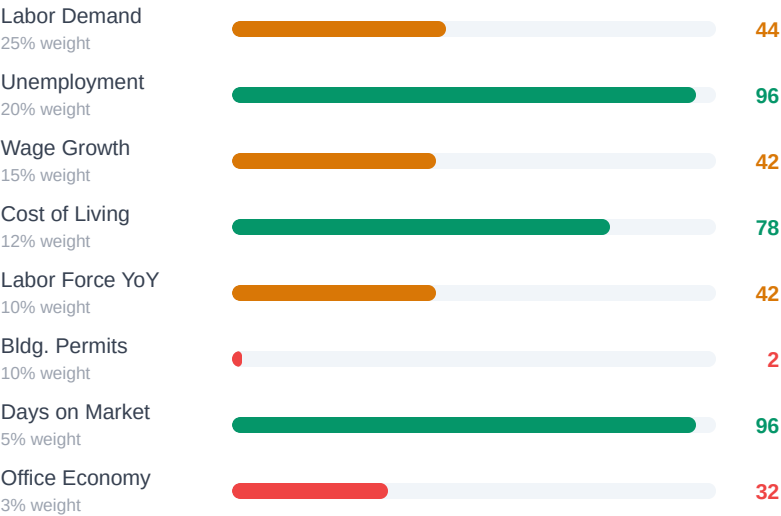
Columbus

Columbus

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
56.0th percentile
Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus, with an overall grade of B+ and a composite score ranking it at the 56.0th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 3.40% and a cost of living that is more affordable than most peers, with a ratio of \$206/sqft to \$34.44/hr. The city's economic character is also marked by near-median labor demand and wage growth. Specifically, the labor demand composite score of 4.36 and wage growth of +3.26% YoY suggest a stable, though not exceptionally strong, economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.22% YoY and weekly hours deviation of -0.246% from the city's own trend indicate a near-median labor demand composite score. This combination signals a modest expansion in jobs but with hours worked slightly below trend, suggesting some degree of labor market stability rather than genuine demand expansion or contraction. The labor market is neither strongly tightening nor loosening.

Unemployment

With an unemployment rate of 3.40%, Columbus has a very tight labor market, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is small, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate suggests that workers have significant bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +3.26% is near the median, indicating moderate wage increases. This rate of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate, and worker purchasing power is increasing, though not dramatically. The moderate wage growth supports a stable labor market.

Cost of Living

Columbus is more affordable than most of its peers, with a cost of living percentile rank of 78th, driven by a PSF of \$206/sqft that is decreasing by -1.4% YoY relative to wages of \$34.44/hr. This affordability advantage means that the city can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for high living costs. The decreasing PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this advantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -0.33% YoY, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to adapt their hiring strategies to this shrinking labor market.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -41.29%, a sharp decline that signals a tightening housing supply. This decline suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. The sharp drop in permits is a concern for long-term labor market health.

Days on Market

Homes are currently sitting on the market for 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of +16.1%, indicating a slower market. This slower market means that workers relocating to Columbus may find it more accessible to purchase a home, as there is less competition and pressure to act quickly. The rising days on market suggests a normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share percentile rank of 32nd, Columbus has a less deep professional talent pool compared to many of its peers. This city is less suited for businesses requiring a large pool of specialized office or tech talent but may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs, such as logistics or manufacturing. The relatively low rank suggests that businesses seeking a deep knowledge-economy talent pool may need to look elsewhere.

In conclusion, Columbus offers businesses a stable economic environment with an exceptionally low unemployment rate and a more affordable cost of living, which can be an advantage in attracting talent. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the sharp decline in building permits, which signals potential future challenges in housing affordability and workforce accommodation, and the contracting labor force, which may complicate hiring efforts.

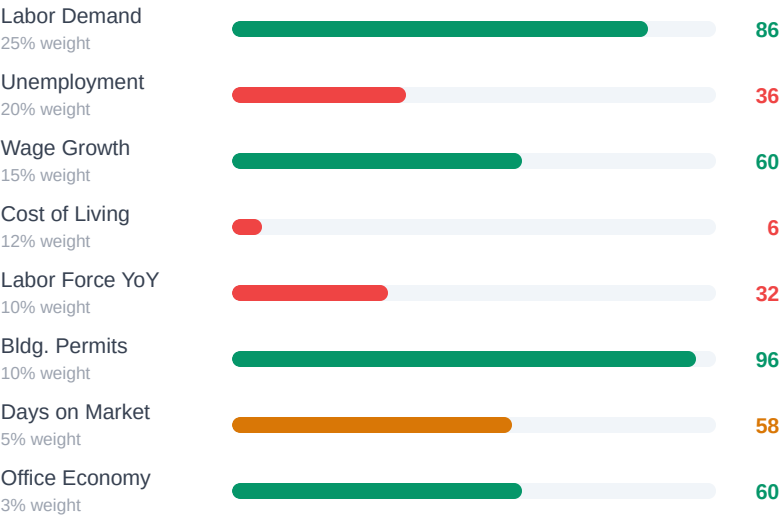
Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
55.9th percentile
Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 55.9th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with an employment growth rate of 1.83% and a labor demand composite score in the top tier at the 86th percentile, as well as its rapidly expanding housing supply, signaled by a 112.64% year-over-year increase in building permits. These metrics suggest a city with genuine job growth and a proactive approach to accommodating its workforce.

Labor Demand

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is experiencing employment growth at a rate of 1.83% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of -0.727% from its own 12-month baseline, indicating a genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and, despite a slight decrease in hours worked, is still experiencing a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.14 further supports this, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area stands at 4.80%, ranking below average at the 36th percentile. This indicates that the job market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the relatively moderate unemployment rate also suggests that local consumer demand may not be as strong as in areas with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

Year-over-year wage growth in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is 4.84%, placing it above average at the 60th percentile. This rate of wage growth is relatively fast, implying rising labor costs for employers but also increased purchasing power for workers. Businesses should anticipate higher wage bills but also a workforce with enhanced consumer spending potential.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$667/sqft to \$41.74/hr, resulting in a ratio of 15.98, and a year-over-year decrease of 3.3% in PSF, the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area ranks in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile for affordability. This means the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could hinder talent attraction without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is shrinking at a rate of -0.54% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 32nd percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may face

challenges in finding sufficient skilled workers to fill open positions.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is a significant 112.64% increase, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This substantial expansion in housing supply signals improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future. It suggests that the city is proactively addressing potential housing shortages and supporting its growing population.

Days on Market

Homes in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area currently sit on the market for a median of 46 days, with a year-over-year increase of 4.5%. This places the city near the median at the 58th percentile for days on market. For workers relocating to this city, the market is relatively competitive but not overly challenging, indicating a balanced environment for buyers and sellers.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is above average, ranking at the 60th percentile. This indicates a deep talent pool suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses but less ideal for those requiring large industrial or logistics workforces.

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a rapidly expanding housing supply, which are significant advantages for attracting and accommodating a workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the relatively high cost of living, which could necessitate wage premiums to attract top talent, potentially increasing labor costs for employers.

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

B

AVERAGE

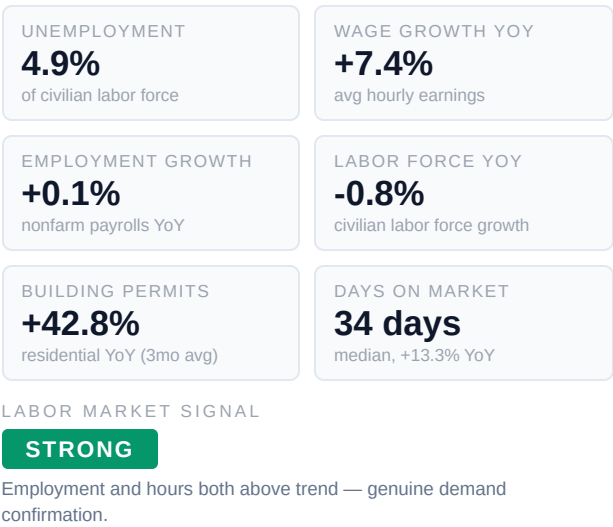
54.4th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 54.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and office economy. The city's economic character is defined by its top-tier wage growth of 7.37% year-over-year and its significant share of professional and office workers, ranking in the 84th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with a deep talent pool and rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an employment growth rate of 0.08% year-over-year and weekly hours 0.67% above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a moderate increase in job creation, with hours worked also increasing, suggesting that businesses are not only hiring but also utilizing their workforce more intensively. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 4.90%, ranking in the 10th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face significant challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The tight labor market also suggests that workers have strong bargaining power, which could drive up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 7.37%, ranking in the 96th percentile, indicating very fast wage growth. This rapid wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers will increase, but it also means that workers will have more purchasing power, which could benefit local businesses. The strong wage growth is a double-edged sword, offering benefits to workers but increasing costs for employers.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue, with a price-to-salary ratio of 9.50 and a PSF of \$452/sqft that is falling 2.8% year-over-year, ranks in the 39th percentile, indicating that the city is relatively expensive. However, the falling PSF suggests that the city may become more affordable in the future. The relatively high cost of living means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, but the falling PSF could mitigate this issue over time.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is shrinking at a rate of -0.80% year-over-year, ranking in the 22nd percentile, indicating a contracting labor pool. This decline in the labor force suggests that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring, as the supply of

workers is decreasing. The shrinking labor force could exacerbate the tight labor market, making it even more challenging for businesses to find talent.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has increased by 42.78% year-over-year, ranking in the 90th percentile, indicating a significant expansion of housing supply. This increase in building permits suggests that the city is investing in its future housing stock, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The expanding housing supply could help mitigate the city's affordability issues and make it more attractive to workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 34 days, with a year-over-year increase of 13.3%, ranking in the 92nd percentile, indicating a slower market. This means that homes are taking longer to sell, making the market more accessible to relocating workers. The slower market could give workers more time to find a home, reducing the stress and competition associated with relocating to a new city.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is significant, ranking in the 84th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized workers. However, the city may be less suitable for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors, which require a different type of workforce.

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, a deep talent pool, and a growing housing supply, making it an attractive location for companies in the tech and finance sectors. However, the city's tight labor market and high cost of living pose significant risks, and businesses should carefully consider these factors when making location decisions. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the tight labor market, which could drive up labor costs and make it challenging to attract and retain talent.

New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

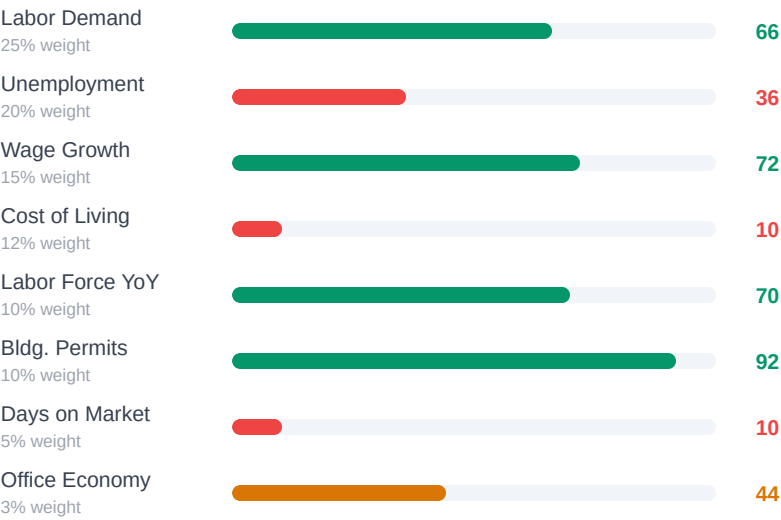
B

AVERAGE

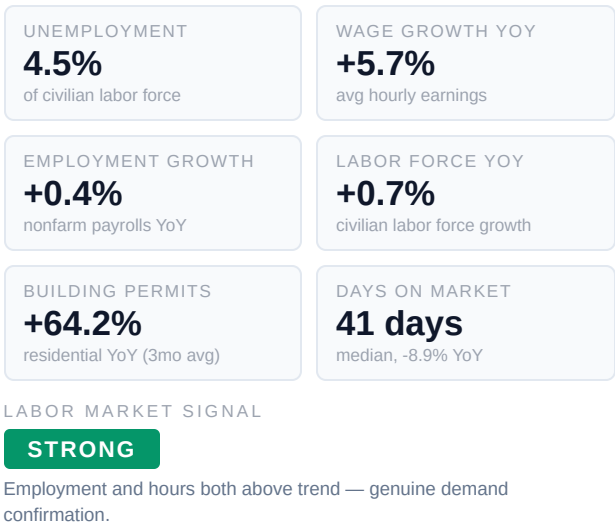
53.7th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 53.7th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and strong wage growth, at 66th and 72nd percentiles, respectively. The city's labor market is characterized by a 0.39% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.456% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. These metrics signal a genuine demand expansion in the city's labor market.

Labor Demand

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an employment growth rate of 0.39% year-over-year and a weekly hours deviation of 0.456% above its own trend, indicating a genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.30 places the city at the 66th percentile, further reinforcing the notion of a thriving labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is 4.50%, which is below average, ranking at the 36th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. As a result, businesses may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is 5.68%, which is above average, ranking at the 72nd percentile. This rapid wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers may be rising, but it also indicates strong purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, but they can also expect a skilled and affluent workforce.

Cost of Living

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has a cost of living score that places it at the 10th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$540/sqft to \$41.11/hr, or 13.14. Although the PSF is decreasing by 1.3% year-over-year, the city remains relatively expensive. This means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is growing at a rate of 0.73% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking at the 70th percentile. This expansion in labor force supply suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is increasing by 64.22% year-over-year, which is a top-tier growth rate, ranking at the 92nd percentile. This surge in building permits suggests that the city's housing supply is expanding, which may lead to improved affordability and a more attractive environment for workers to relocate.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is 41 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 8.9%. This relatively fast pace of home sales, ranking at the 10th percentile, may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing, potentially affecting their decision to move to the city.

Office Economy

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an office economy score that places it at the 44th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 2.40 out of 5. This suggests that the city has a moderately deep talent pool, making it suitable for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but potentially less attractive for industrial or logistics-dominant companies.

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and rapid wage growth, but it also presents challenges such as a tight labor market and high cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's expensive housing market, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract and retain top talent.

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

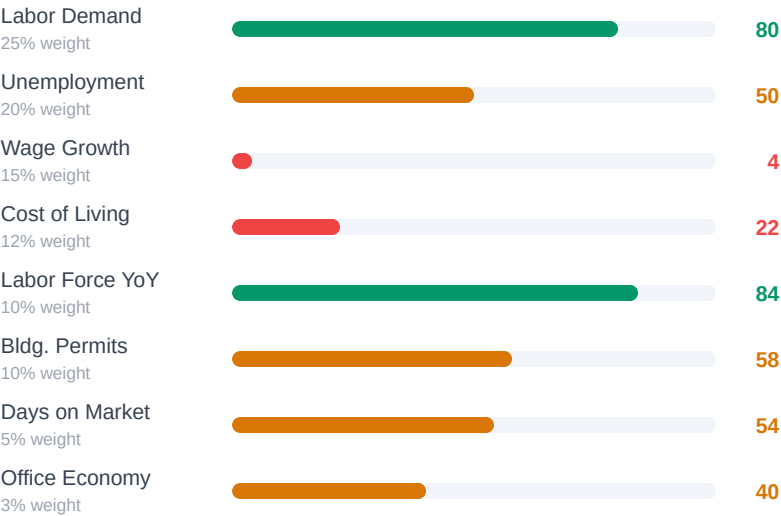
B

AVERAGE

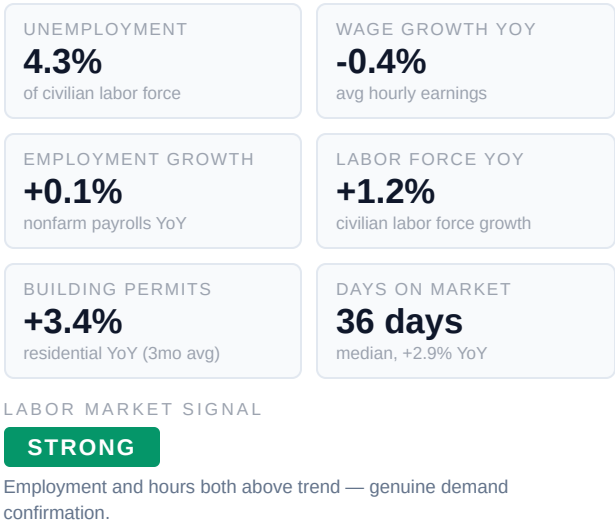
51.4th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking at the 51.4th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and labor force growth, scoring in the top tier at the 80th and 84th percentiles respectively. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.92, combining a +0.12% employment growth rate and a +1.451% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. This, coupled with its labor force growth, defines the city's current economic character.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.12% and weekly hours deviation of +1.451% from its own trend indicate a genuine demand expansion, suggesting that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or relocate. This combination signals that the labor market is strong, with employers adding jobs and workers putting in more hours. The labor demand composite score of 5.92 further reinforces this notion, placing the city in the top tier.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.30% places the city near the median, indicating a relatively balanced labor market with neither too much slack nor too much tightness. This rate suggests that while it may not be overly difficult to find talent, the market is not so loose that it lacks competition for jobs. For a business trying to hire, this means a moderate level of challenge in finding the right candidates without excessive wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of -0.37% is in the bottom tier, at the 4th percentile, indicating stagnant or even slightly decreasing wages. This slow wage growth implies that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing, which could affect local consumer demand. For businesses, this could mean a flat cost environment, but it also suggests weaker bargaining power for workers.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$231/sqft to \$32.82/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.04, and a percentile rank of 22, the city is less affordable than many of its peers. The fact that PSF is decreasing by -0.4% YoY slightly mitigates this, but overall, the city's affordability is below average. This means that attracting talent without offering wage premiums could be challenging, as the cost of living is relatively high compared to earnings.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +1.25% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city has a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity, as the pool of potential workers is increasing. For businesses, this means a more favorable environment for finding and recruiting talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +3.44%, which is near the median, suggesting a modest expansion in housing supply. This growth indicates that developer confidence is present, and future housing supply is likely to increase, which could improve affordability and make the city more attractive for relocating workers. However, the rate is not exceptionally high, so the impact on affordability might be gradual.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.9%, placing it near the median in terms of market speed. This indicates a relatively balanced market where homes are not selling excessively quickly, but also not lingering on the market for too long. For a worker relocating to this city, the market is neither overly competitive nor excessively slow, making it moderately accessible.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share composite score of 2.38, ranking at the 40th percentile, the city has a moderately deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This suggests that the city is suited for businesses that require a knowledge-economy workforce, such as tech, finance, or consulting, but may not be as ideal for industries with different workforce needs.

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and growing labor force, making it an attractive location for expansion or relocation. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the relatively high cost of living, which could necessitate wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially offsetting some of the benefits of the city's otherwise favorable economic conditions.

San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

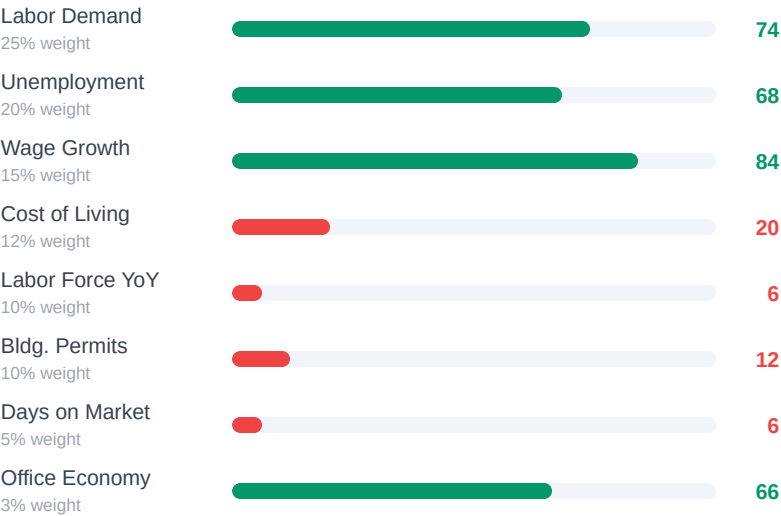
B

AVERAGE

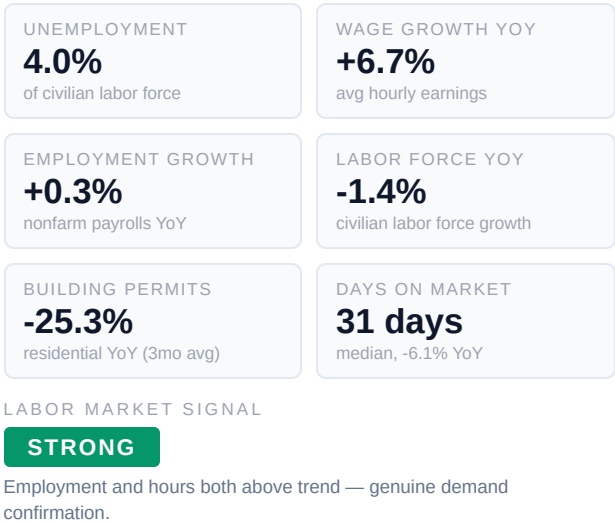
51.2th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 51.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and high wage growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.84, which combines a +0.34% employment growth rate and a +1.065% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. This, coupled with its top-tier wage growth, defines the city's current economic character.

Labor Demand

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an employment growth rate of +0.34% and a weekly hours deviation of +1.065% from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours than usual, suggesting a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 5.84 is above average, ranking in the 74th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 4.00%, which is above average, ranking in the 68th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward wage pressure. As a result, businesses may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is +6.70%, ranking in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This rapid wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising quickly, while workers are experiencing increased purchasing power. Businesses should factor in these rising labor costs when considering relocation or expansion in this city.

Cost of Living

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has a cost of living score that ranks in the 20th percentile, indicating that it is relatively expensive. The city's PSF of \$662/sqft, which is decreasing by -3.1% year-over-year, combined with an hourly wage of \$50.65, results in a ratio of 13.07. This suggests that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is shrinking at a rate of -1.40% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find and recruit top talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has decreased by -25.29% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile. This sharp decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 31 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -6.1%. This indicates a competitive housing market, which may make it difficult for relocating workers to find and secure housing. The bottom-tier ranking of 6th percentile suggests that the market is moving quickly, favoring sellers over buyers.

Office Economy

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking in the 66th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and high wage growth environment, making it an attractive location for companies seeking to tap into a talented and productive workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's high cost of living and tightening housing supply, which may pose significant challenges for attracting and retaining top talent without offering substantial wage premiums.

Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

B

AVERAGE

51.0th percentile

Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		62
Unemployment 20% weight		28
Wage Growth 15% weight		26
Cost of Living 12% weight		96
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		60
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		22
Days on Market 5% weight		78
Office Economy 3% weight		80

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.4% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +1.9% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.2% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.3% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -18.4% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 48 days median, +9.1% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 51.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and highly affordable cost of living, scoring 62nd and 96th percentiles, respectively. The labor demand composite score of 5.18, combining a 0.22% employment growth rate and a 0.569% increase in weekly hours, suggests genuine demand expansion. This, coupled with a cost of living ratio of \$173/sqft to \$36.90/hr, indicates a favorable environment for businesses and workers alike.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.22% and the 0.569% increase in weekly hours above the city's own trend signal genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This combination indicates that the labor market is experiencing an increase in jobs and workload, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 5.18 further reinforces this notion, ranking in the 62nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.40% is below the national average, ranking in the 28th percentile, which means the market has some slack but is still relatively tight. For a business trying to hire in this market, the implication is that while it may not be extremely difficult to find talent, wages may still be under pressure due to the relatively low unemployment rate. This could impact hiring strategies and compensation packages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 1.85% is below average, ranking in the 26th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This implies that labor costs for employers are not rising too quickly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing rapidly. For businesses, this means a relatively stable labor cost environment, but workers may not see significant increases in their purchasing power.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$173/sqft to \$36.90/hr and a percentile rank of 96th, Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is highly affordable relative to its peers. The PSF is also falling by 2.3% year-over-year, making it even more attractive. This affordability means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 0.29% year-over-year, ranking in the 60th percentile, indicating that the workforce supply is expanding. This growth in the labor force implies that hiring capacity should not be significantly constrained by a lack of available workers,

making it easier for businesses to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -18.37%, ranking in the 22nd percentile, which signals that housing supply is tightening. This decrease in building permits may lead to future affordability issues and could make it more challenging for the workforce to find accommodation, potentially impacting the city's attractiveness to relocating workers and businesses.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 48 days, with a year-over-year increase of 9.1%, ranking in the 78th percentile. This indicates a slower market, which could be more accessible for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find a suitable home. However, this also suggests that the housing market may be normalizing after a period of rapid growth.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share composite score ranking in the 80th percentile, Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in these sectors but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, affordable cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for various industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the significant decrease in building permits, which could impact future affordability and workforce accommodation.

Memphis

Memphis

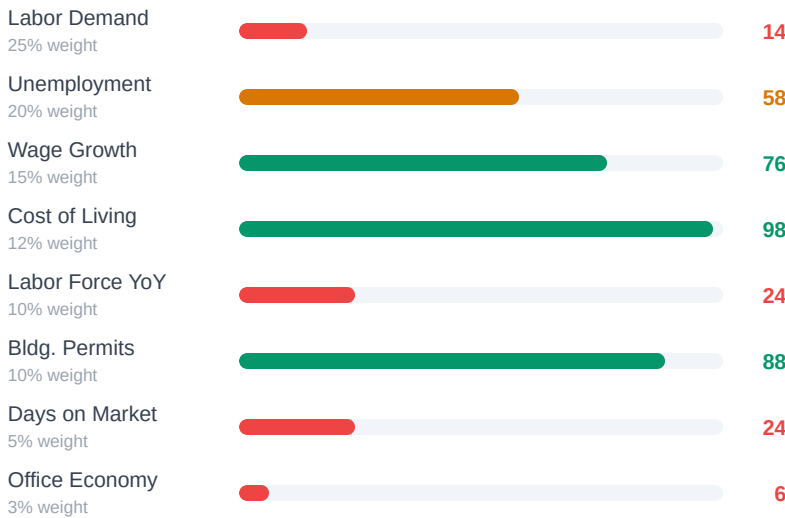
B

AVERAGE

50.8th percentile

Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.2%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+6.2%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.1%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.8%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+39.1%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

54 days

median, -3.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Memphis has an overall grade of B, ranking 50.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and highly affordable cost of living, scoring 76th and 98th percentiles respectively. The city's economic character is defined by these two metrics, with wage growth at 6.18% year-over-year and a cost of living ratio of \$155/sqft to \$32.45/hr, indicating a very affordable environment. This affordability is further underscored by the PSF falling 6.1% year-over-year.

Labor Demand

Memphis has an employment growth rate of -0.11% and weekly hours 1.898% above its own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 2.65, which ranks in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as the slight increase in hours worked does not offset the decline in employment growth, potentially indicating a survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles. This scenario suggests that while there may be some demand for labor, it is not strong enough to drive significant job growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Memphis is 4.20%, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This rate indicates a relatively balanced market, neither too tight nor too slack, suggesting that businesses may face moderate challenges in hiring but without extreme wage pressure. For a business trying to hire in Memphis, this means they can expect to find suitable candidates without overly inflated wage expectations, but may still need to compete to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 6.18%, Memphis experiences above-average wage increases, ranking in the 76th percentile. This fast wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers but also indicates strong worker purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local consumer demand. Businesses should factor in these increasing labor costs when considering operations in Memphis.

Cost of Living

Memphis has a highly affordable cost of living, with a percentile rank of 98th, driven by a PSF to earnings ratio of \$155/sqft to \$32.45/hr, and a year-over-year decrease in PSF of 6.1%. This affordability advantage means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs, making Memphis an attractive location for companies looking to minimize labor costs while still offering a high quality of life.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Memphis is shrinking at a rate of -0.76% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 24th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses should be aware that finding and retaining talent may become increasingly challenging in this environment.

Building Permits

Memphis has seen a significant increase in residential building permits, with a year-over-year change of +39.08%, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile. This expansion in housing supply suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation are likely to improve, as more housing options become available. This trend is positive for businesses considering relocation, as it indicates a potential easing of housing costs and increased attractiveness for relocating workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Memphis is 54 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -3.6%. This relatively fast market, ranking below average at the 24th percentile, means that homes are selling quickly, which can be challenging for relocating workers. However, the slight decrease in days on market may indicate a normalization of the housing market, potentially making it slightly more accessible for new residents.

Office Economy

Memphis has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industries with less specialized labor requirements, like logistics or manufacturing. Decision-makers should consider whether their business needs align with the available talent pool in Memphis.

In conclusion, Memphis offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and an extremely affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies looking to balance labor costs with talent attraction. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force, which may pose significant challenges for hiring and retaining talent in the long term.

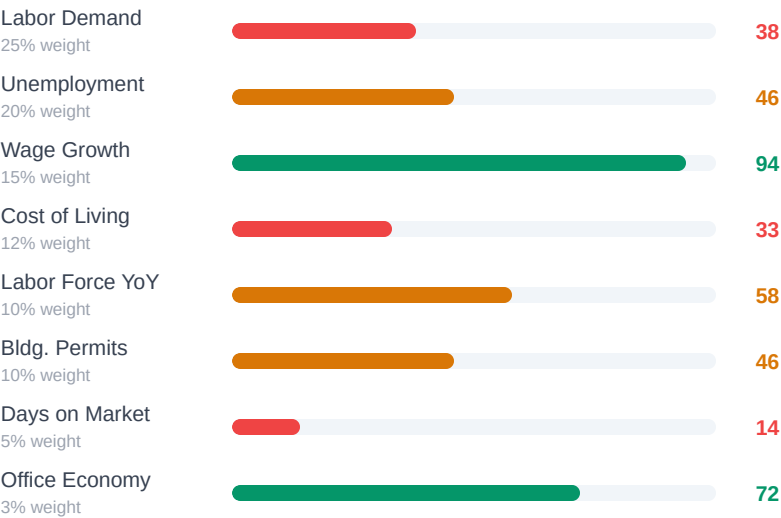
Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

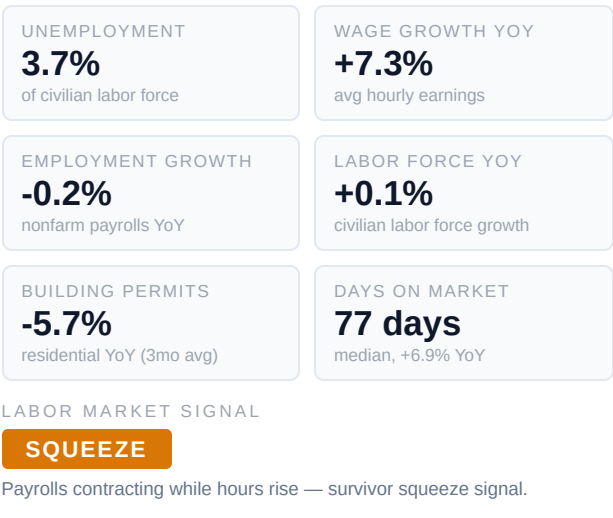
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
50.0th percentile
Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has an overall grade of B- and ranks at the 50.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 3.78, indicating below-average performance. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 7.30%, and its below-average labor demand, with employment growth of -0.25% and weekly hours deviation of +0.166%. These metrics suggest a complex economic environment with both positive and negative trends.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of -0.25% and weekly hours deviation of +0.166% indicate a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion. This combination signals a potential survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 3.78, ranking at the 38th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.70% ranks at the 46th percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This suggests that the market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire, but still with some wage pressure. The relatively low unemployment rate implies that businesses may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 7.30% is exceptionally high, ranking at the 94th percentile. This rapid wage growth signals rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing worker purchasing power. Businesses should be prepared for higher labor costs, but also expect a skilled and motivated workforce.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 10.55, based on \$359/sqft (decreasing by 1.6% year-over-year) and \$34.04/hr, Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach ranks at the 33rd percentile, indicating a below-average level of affordability. This means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the cost of living is relatively high compared to peers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 0.15% year-over-year, ranking at the 58th percentile. This slow growth rate indicates that the labor force supply is expanding, but at a moderate pace. Businesses can expect a gradually increasing pool of potential employees, but may still face challenges in finding skilled workers.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -5.72%, ranking at the 46th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation. Businesses should be aware of the potential for future affordability challenges and plan accordingly.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 77 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.9%, ranking at the 14th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell. For workers relocating to this city, the market may be more accessible, with less competition for housing.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share of 3.20, ranking at the 72nd percentile, Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. However, the city may be less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses, which require a different type of workforce.

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy companies. However, the city's below-average labor demand and relatively high cost of living may pose challenges for businesses looking to hire and retain top talent, and the single biggest risk is the potential for future affordability challenges and decreased workforce accommodation.

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.9th percentile
Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		92
25% weight		
Unemployment		10
20% weight		
Wage Growth		36
15% weight		
Cost of Living		74
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		80
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		0
10% weight		
Days on Market		16
5% weight		
Office Economy		64
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.4% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +2.8% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.1% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +1.1% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -54.3% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 68 days median, +9.7% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 49.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 92nd percentile, and its struggling housing market, with building permits declining by 54.27% year-over-year. The labor demand is driven by employment growth of 1.08% and weekly hours 1.057% above trend.

Labor Demand

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has an employment growth rate of 1.08% and weekly hours 1.057% above its own 12-month trend, signaling genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.87 is in the top tier at the 92nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is 4.40%, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there are fewer unemployed workers available, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The tight market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is 2.81%, which is below average at the 36th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and workers have some, but not significant, purchasing power gains. The wage growth is not stagnant, but it is not fast enough to drive significant economic expansion.

Cost of Living

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a cost of living score in the above-average tier at the 74th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$224/sqft to \$33.47/hr, or 6.69. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage without requiring wage premiums. The PSF is also falling by 3.5% year-over-year, making the city even more affordable.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is growing at a rate of 1.14% year-over-year, which is in the top tier at the 80th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, making it easier for businesses to hire and find talent. The growing labor force also suggests that the city has a strong pipeline of potential workers.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has declined by 54.27% year-over-year, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 0th percentile. This sharp decline suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The lack of new housing construction may also limit the city's ability to attract new residents and businesses.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is 68 days, with a year-over-year increase of 9.7%. This suggests that the housing market is slowing down, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the relatively low days on market percentile rank of 16th percentile indicates that the market is still relatively competitive.

Office Economy

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has an office economy score in the above-average tier at the 64th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 2.98 out of 5. This indicates that the city has a relatively deep talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. However, it may not be as suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent and investment. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the tightening housing market, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce, making it essential for decision-makers to factor in the potential impact of housing supply constraints on their operations.

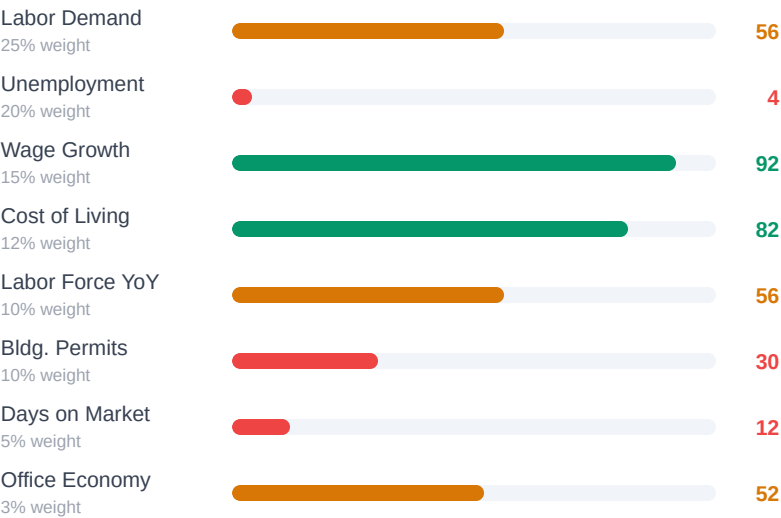
Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

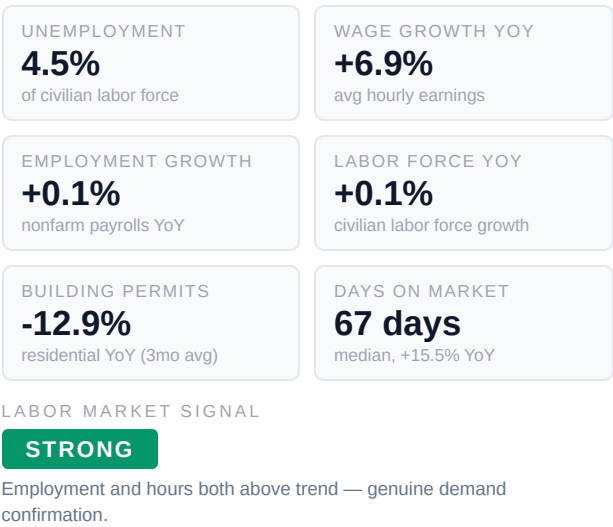
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.2th percentile
Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 49.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 6.90% year-over-year and its low unemployment rate of 4.50%, which signals a tight labor market. The combination of these two metrics suggests that the city is experiencing strong labor demand, but also faces challenges in terms of hiring and wage pressure.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 0.12% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by 0.409%. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. However, the labor demand composite score is near median at 56th percentile, indicating that the city's labor market is not exceptionally strong.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 4.50%, which is relatively low and indicates a tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is small, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that there may be upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 6.90%, which is relatively high and indicates strong labor cost growth for employers. This also means that workers in the city have good purchasing power, which can drive local consumer demand. However, the high wage growth rate may also lead to increased labor costs for businesses.

Cost of Living

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a cost of living score that ranks at the 82nd percentile, indicating that it is relatively affordable compared to other cities. The city's PSF is \$242/sqft, which is decreasing by 2.8% year-over-year, and the average hourly earnings are \$37.36/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.48. This affordability advantage can help attract talent without requiring wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is growing at a rate of 0.14% year-over-year, which is near median and indicates that the workforce supply is slowly expanding. This moderate growth rate suggests that hiring capacity is not severely constrained, but may not be exceptionally strong either.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has decreased by 12.90% year-over-year, which signals that housing supply is tightening. This decrease in building permits may lead to future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation, as the supply of new housing units is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is currently 67 days, and has increased by 15.5% year-over-year. This indicates a slower market, which can make it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the relatively low percentile rank of 12th suggests that the market is still relatively competitive.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is near median, ranking at the 52nd percentile. This suggests that the city has a moderate-sized talent pool suited for tech, finance, and consulting businesses, but may not be as deep as in other cities. The city is best suited for businesses that require a general professional workforce, but may not be ideal for those requiring highly specialized talent.

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, low unemployment, and relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation.

Cleveland

Cleveland

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.0th percentile
Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		52
Unemployment 20% weight		68
Wage Growth 15% weight		2
Cost of Living 12% weight		50
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		92
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		24
Days on Market 5% weight		46
Office Economy 3% weight		74

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 3.4%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings -0.6%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY +0.6%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth +1.8%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -18.2%	DAYS ON MARKET median, +7.8% YoY 55 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland earns an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 49.0th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its stagnant wage growth and strong labor force expansion, with a year-over-year wage growth rate of -0.55% and a labor force growth rate of +1.80%. These metrics suggest a complex labor market with both opportunities and challenges for businesses.

Labor Demand

Cleveland's employment growth rate is +0.57% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.363% below trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.73, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile. This combination signals a moderate labor market with some genuine demand expansion, but not enough to drive significant hours growth. The labor demand is neither strongly expanding nor contracting.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cleveland is 3.40%, ranking above average at the 68th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with more wage pressure due to the limited availability of workers. However, the current rate still suggests some slack in the market, allowing for selective hiring.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of -0.55%, Cleveland experiences stagnant wage growth, ranking at the bottom tier of the 2nd percentile. This implies that labor costs for employers are not increasing significantly, but worker purchasing power is also not growing. The stagnant wage environment may attract businesses looking for a flat cost structure but could limit worker bargaining power.

Cost of Living

Cleveland's cost of living, with a PSF of \$143/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$33.75, results in a ratio of 4.24, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. Given the 13.5% year-over-year increase in PSF, the city is relatively average in terms of affordability. This means that Cleveland does not offer a significant talent attraction advantage without wage premiums, as its cost of living is neither particularly high nor low compared to peers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cleveland is growing at a rate of +1.80% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, providing a positive environment for hiring, as businesses can tap into a growing pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Cleveland have decreased by -18.19% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 24th percentile. This decline suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

Homes in Cleveland currently sit on the market for 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.8%. This ranks near the median at the 46th percentile, indicating a moderate market. For relocating workers, this means that the housing market is relatively accessible, with homes not selling extremely quickly, allowing for some flexibility in finding a place to live.

Office Economy

Cleveland's professional and office worker share is above average, ranking at the 74th percentile. This suggests a deep talent pool suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, or headquarters operations. However, it may be less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

In conclusion, Cleveland offers businesses a unique combination of a growing labor force and a relatively tight labor market, but with stagnant wage growth and tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for future affordability issues and workforce accommodation challenges due to the decline in residential building permits, which could offset the benefits of the city's expanding labor pool.

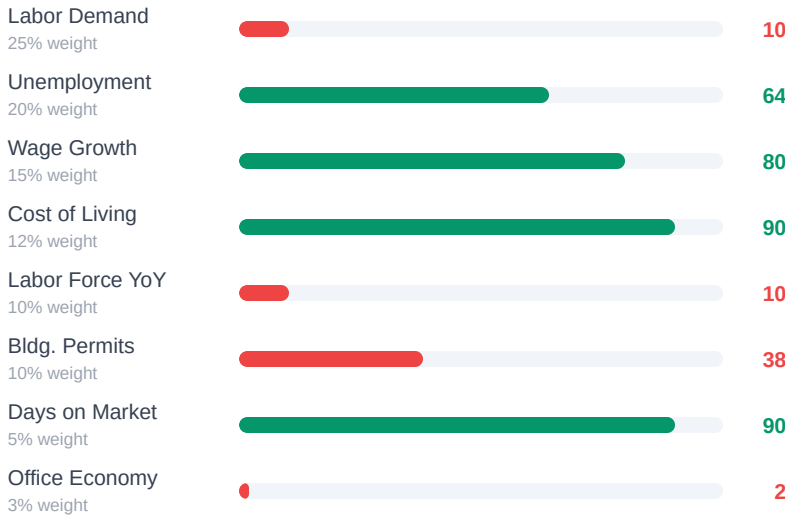
Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
47.4th percentile
Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.4%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+6.2%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
-1.0%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-1.2%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-9.7%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
51 days
median, +18.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 47.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its high wage growth, at 6.23% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a complex environment where businesses may face challenges in finding and retaining talent.

Labor Demand

Oklahoma City's employment growth rate is -0.96% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from trend by +0.677%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, with hours above trend potentially indicating a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 2.28 is in the bottom tier, confirming this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Oklahoma City is 3.40%, ranking in the 64th percentile, indicating a relatively tight market. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available talent, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract workers. The tight labor market implies upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Oklahoma City is 6.23% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier. This fast wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. Businesses operating in this city should be prepared for higher labor costs, but may also benefit from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

Oklahoma City has a cost of living score in the top tier, with a PSF of \$173/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$33.90/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.10. The city's PSF is also falling by -0.6% year-over-year, making it more affordable relative to wages. This means that Oklahoma City has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford a higher standard of living without requiring wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Oklahoma City is shrinking at a rate of -1.21% year-over-year. This contraction in labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find and recruit talent. The shrinking labor pool may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Oklahoma City are falling by -9.74% year-over-year. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation. The decrease in building permits is a concern for businesses that rely on a growing and affordable housing stock to attract workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Oklahoma City is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of 18.6%. This slower market, ranking in the top tier, means that workers relocating to this city may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market. The rising days on market may indicate a healthy normalization of the housing market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

Oklahoma City's professional and office worker share is relatively low, ranking in the 2nd percentile. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not particularly deep in specialized office roles, making it less suited for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors. However, the city may be more attractive to businesses in industrial or logistics sectors.

Oklahoma City offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent. However, the city's low labor demand and shrinking labor force supply are significant concerns that may limit business growth and hiring capacity. Decision-makers should carefully weigh these factors when considering Oklahoma City as a business location.

Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.8th percentile
Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		68
Unemployment 20% weight		36
Wage Growth 15% weight		42
Cost of Living 12% weight		51
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		16
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		36
Days on Market 5% weight		38
Office Economy 3% weight		68

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.0% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +3.3% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.6% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.0% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -9.8% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 57 days median, +9.6% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 45.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, with a composite score at the 68th percentile, and its below-average labor force growth, which is contracting at a rate of -0.96% year-over-year. The labor demand and labor force growth metrics are crucial in understanding the city's current economic landscape, with the 68th percentile labor demand indicating a strong job market and the -0.96% labor force growth signaling a shrinking workforce.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is +0.62% year-over-year, combined with a +0.193% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or relocate. The above-average labor demand composite score of 5.36 further supports this trend.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 4.00%, which ranks at the 36th percentile, indicating a below-average score. This means that the job market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire workers compared to cities with tighter labor markets. However, the unemployment rate is not low enough to indicate a significant surplus of workers, and businesses may still face some competition for top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is +3.26%, ranking at the 42nd percentile, which is near the median. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate. At the same time, workers are experiencing an increase in purchasing power, which can have a positive impact on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$272/sqft to \$37.62/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.23, Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler ranks at the 51st percentile in terms of affordability. This near-median ranking indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, with a slight decline in PSF of -1.8% year-over-year. This affordability can be a talent attraction advantage for businesses, as workers may not require significant wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is contracting at a rate of -0.96% year-over-year, ranking at the 16th percentile. This decline in labor force supply can create a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find and attract workers. As the labor force shrinks, businesses may need to offer more competitive wages or benefits to attract top talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is -9.77%, ranking at the 36th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which can lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future. This trend may pose a risk to workforce accommodation and talent attraction, as workers may be deterred by high housing costs.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 57 days, with a year-over-year increase of +9.6%. This below-average ranking of 38th percentile indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell. For workers relocating to this city, the slower market can be a competitive advantage, as they may have more time to find and secure housing.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share of 3.14, ranking at the 68th percentile, Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge-economy workers, but may not be the best fit for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant workforces.

In conclusion, Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler offers a strong labor demand and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for businesses. However, the city's contracting labor force growth and tightening housing supply pose significant risks to workforce accommodation and talent attraction, which decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating this location.

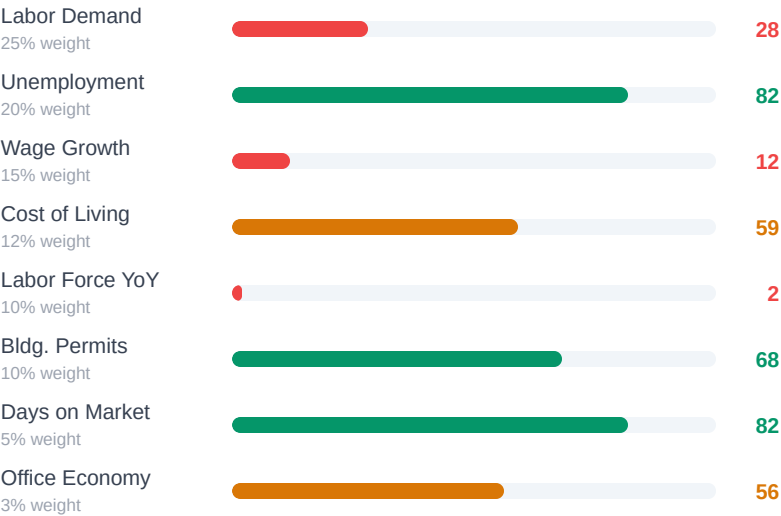
Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

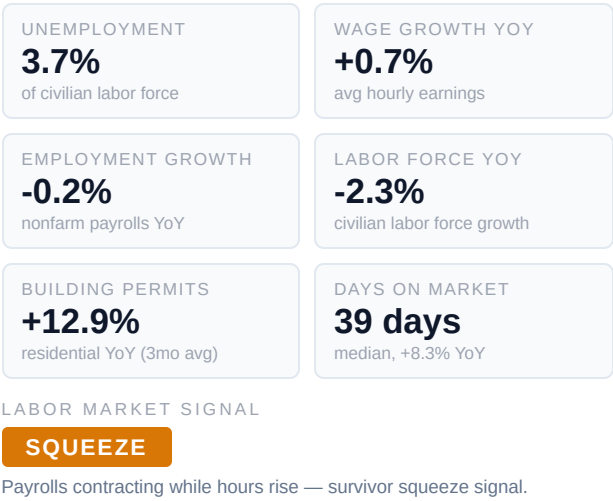
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.1th percentile
Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 45.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score ranking at the 28th percentile, and its tight unemployment market, with a rate of 3.70% ranking at the 82nd percentile. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is -0.24% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.467%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not adding jobs at a significant rate, and the slight increase in hours worked may be due to a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 3.70%, ranking at the 82nd percentile, indicating a tight market with low unemployment. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is +0.74%, ranking at the 12th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies that workers may have weak bargaining power and limited purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a cost of living score ranking at the 59th percentile, with a PSF of \$293/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$42.65/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.87. This indicates that the city is near the median in terms of affordability, meaning that it may not have a significant talent attraction advantage without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is contracting at a rate of -2.34% year-over-year, ranking at the 2nd percentile. This means that the supply of workers is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring and potentially limiting the city's ability to support business growth.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is increasing by +12.87% year-over-year, ranking at the 68th percentile. This signals that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and support workforce accommodation in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of +8.3%, ranking at the 82nd percentile. This indicates a slower market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city, as homes are taking longer to sell.

Office Economy

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a professional and office worker share ranking at the 56th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This makes the city suitable for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area offers businesses a tight labor market with low unemployment, but also presents challenges in terms of labor demand and labor force growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force, which may limit the city's ability to support business expansion and growth.

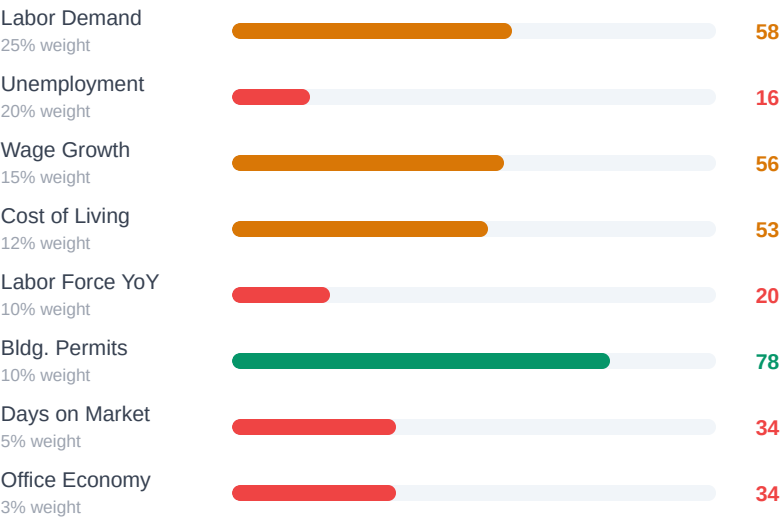
Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

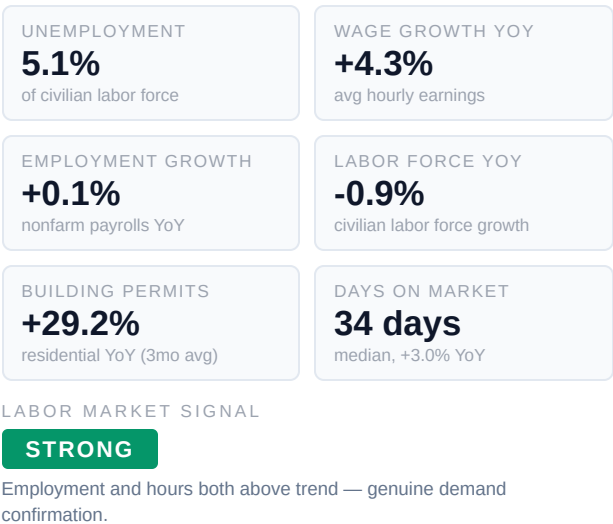
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.0th percentile
Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 45.0th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, which is near median, and its unemployment rate, which is at 5.10% and ranks in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a mixed economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +0.08% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating +0.475% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.89, which is near median at the 58th percentile. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. However, the growth rate is relatively slow, indicating a moderate pace of labor market expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 5.10%, which ranks in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile, indicating a relatively high level of unemployment compared to other metros. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the practical implication is that local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +4.27%, which is near median at the 56th percentile. This rate indicates moderate wage growth, which is likely to result in rising labor costs for employers. At the same time, workers will benefit from increased purchasing power, which can have a positive impact on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has a cost of living score that ranks near median at the 53rd percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$217/sqft to \$37.11/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.85. This suggests that the city is neither extremely affordable nor extremely expensive compared to its peers. The relatively moderate cost of living means that businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent, but it also does not provide a strong competitive advantage in terms of affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is contracting at a rate of -0.92% year-over-year, which ranks below average at the 20th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is shrinking, which can create a structural headwind for hiring and may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has increased by +29.19% year-over-year, which ranks above average at the 78th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. This trend is likely to have a positive impact on the city's ability to attract and retain workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 34 days, with a year-over-year increase of +3.0%. This ranks below average at the 34th percentile, indicating a relatively fast-paced market. For workers relocating to this city, the housing market may be competitive, making it challenging to find and secure a home quickly.

Office Economy

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has a professional and office worker share that ranks below average at the 34th percentile, with a composite score of 1.98 out of 5. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area offers businesses a mixed economic environment with moderate labor demand and wage growth, but also a shrinking labor force and a relatively high unemployment rate. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the limited labor force growth, which can create challenges for hiring and talent acquisition.

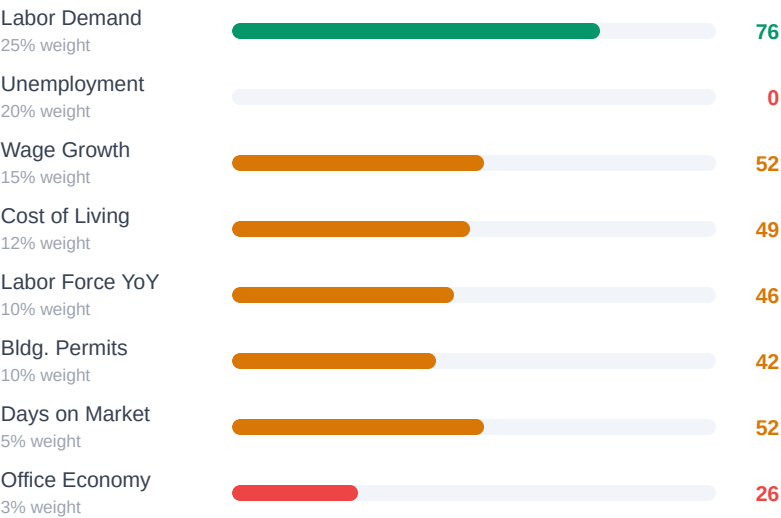
Fresno

Fresno

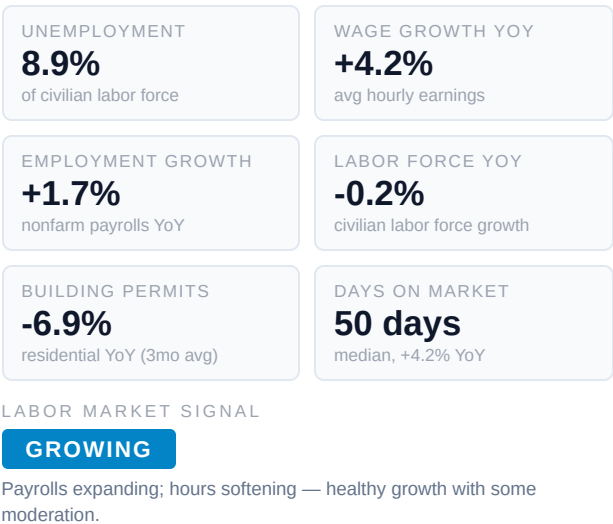
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.9th percentile
Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Fresno has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 44.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its high labor demand composite score of 5.87, ranking it in the 76th percentile, and its high unemployment rate of 8.90%, which ranks it in the bottom tier. These two metrics suggest a complex labor market with both strong job growth and significant slack.

Labor Demand

Fresno's employment growth rate is 1.67% year-over-year, and its weekly hours deviation is -0.768% from its own 12-month baseline, indicating genuine demand expansion. The combination of these two metrics signals that the city is experiencing job growth with hours worked slightly below trend, suggesting that the labor market is expanding but not yet overheating. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Fresno is 8.90%, ranking it in the bottom tier. This indicates that the labor market has significant slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the high unemployment rate also suggests weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses that rely on local spending.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Fresno is 4.17% year-over-year, ranking it near the median in the 52nd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers are seeing their purchasing power increase, which could have positive effects on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Fresno has a cost of living score ranking it in the 49th percentile, with a PSF of \$262/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$33.53/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.81. This near-median ranking suggests that the city is neither extremely affordable nor extremely expensive relative to its peers. The stable PSF growth rate of 0.0% year-over-year indicates that housing costs are not increasing significantly, making it easier for workers to afford housing without requiring large wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Fresno is growing at a rate of -0.17% year-over-year, ranking it near the median in the 46th percentile. This slight contraction in the labor force supply suggests that hiring capacity may be limited in the future, making it more challenging for businesses to find workers.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Fresno is decreasing by 6.89% year-over-year, ranking it near the median in the 42nd percentile. This decline in housing permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Fresno is 50 days, with a year-over-year increase of 4.2%. This suggests that the housing market is slowing down, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the relatively fast pace of sales still indicates a competitive market.

Office Economy

Fresno's office economy is ranked in the 26th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers of 1.74. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies.

In conclusion, Fresno offers a complex labor market with both strong job growth and significant slack, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to hire workers. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in Fresno is the potential for decreased affordability and increased competition for housing due to the tightening housing supply, which could impact their ability to attract and retain workers.

Providence

Providence-Warwick

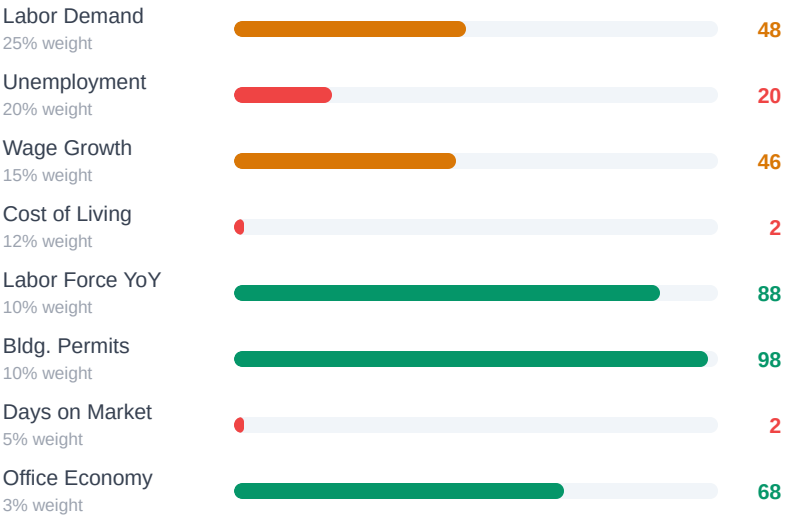
C+

POOR

43.9th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Providence-Warwick metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 43.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.30% and its high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 9.79, ranking it in the 2nd percentile for affordability. The labor force growth rate of +1.69% YoY is also a notable metric, indicating an expanding workforce supply.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Providence-Warwick is +0.60% YoY, while weekly hours are -0.502% below trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.64, ranking near the median at 48th percentile. This combination signals a moderate expansion of genuine demand, as hours are not significantly above trend during job growth. The labor market is not experiencing a survivor squeeze, as job growth is present, albeit slow.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Providence-Warwick is 4.30%, ranking in the 20th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure. The low unemployment rate suggests that workers have more bargaining power, making it essential for employers to offer competitive compensation packages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Providence-Warwick is +3.51%, ranking near the median at 46th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. Workers in this city are experiencing an increase in purchasing power, which can contribute to a stable and growing local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Providence-Warwick has a cost of living percentile rank of 2, indicating that it is an expensive city relative to its peers, with a PSF to wages ratio of 9.79. The PSF is \$359/sqft, which has increased by 7.5% YoY, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The high cost of living may deter some workers from relocating to this city, unless they are offered competitive salaries to offset the expenses.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Providence-Warwick is growing at a rate of +1.69% YoY, ranking in the top tier at 88th percentile. This expanding workforce supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential employees. The increasing

labor force can help mitigate the challenges posed by the low unemployment rate, providing more options for employers.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Providence-Warwick has increased by +132.32% YoY, ranking in the top tier at 98th percentile. This significant rise in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce. The increase in permits is a positive sign for the city's future, as it may help alleviate some of the pressure on the housing market.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Providence-Warwick is 27 days, with a YoY decrease of -6.9%, ranking in the bottom tier at 2nd percentile. This fast-paced market means that homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find available housing. The competitive market may require workers to act rapidly when finding a home, which can be stressful and may impact their decision to relocate to this city.

Office Economy

Providence-Warwick has an office economy percentile rank of 68, indicating a deep professional talent pool. This city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require specialized knowledge-economy workers. However, it may not be the best fit for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant economies, which require different types of workers.

The Providence-Warwick metro area offers businesses a growing labor force and an expanding housing supply, which can support workforce growth and accommodation. However, the city's high cost of living and low unemployment rate pose significant challenges, particularly in terms of attracting and retaining talent without offering substantial wage premiums, which is the single biggest risk or constraint that decision-makers should factor into their location decision.

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

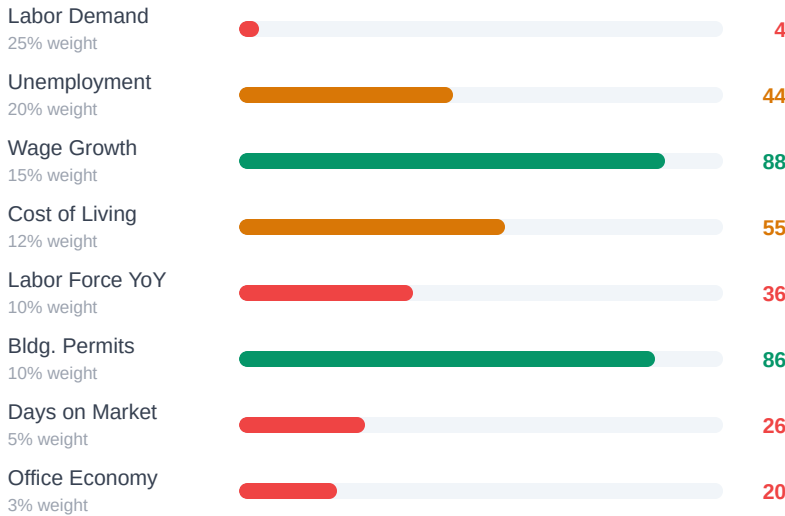
C+

POOR

43.7th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.9%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+6.8%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.7%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.4%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+38.2%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

35 days

median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 43.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a labor demand composite score ranking in the bottom tier at 4th percentile, and strong wage growth, with a year-over-year change in average hourly earnings of +6.78%, ranking in the top tier at 88th percentile. These two metrics signal a complex economic environment with both challenges and opportunities.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in this metro area is -0.73% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +2.049%. However, the combination of these two metrics signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion, as the hours increase is likely due to a survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles. This suggests that the labor market is not expanding, and businesses may face challenges in finding new talent.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 3.90%, which is near the median, ranking at the 44th percentile. This indicates that the labor market has some slack, but it is not extremely loose, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. The practical implication is that businesses may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent, but they are not likely to face extreme wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in this metro area is +6.78%, which is relatively fast, ranking in the top tier at 88th percentile. This signals that labor costs for employers are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, but they can also expect to benefit from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in this metro area is near the median, with a percentile rank of 55th, and a price-to-salary ratio of 6.29, based on \$223/sqft and \$35.44/hr. This means that the city is moderately affordable, but not extremely attractive for talent without wage premiums. The fact that the PSF is rising by +2.3% year-over-year relative to wages may indicate that affordability is decreasing over time.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in this metro area is contracting at a rate of -0.41% year-over-year, which is below average, ranking at the 36th percentile. This implies that the supply of workers is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring. Businesses may need to consider recruiting from outside the area or investing in training and development programs to build the skills they need.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in this metro area is increasing by +38.19% year-over-year, which is a top-tier growth rate, ranking at the 86th percentile. This signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and make it easier for workers to relocate to the area. As a result, businesses may benefit from a more accessible and affordable housing market for their employees.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in this metro area is 35 days, with no year-over-year change. This is a relatively fast market, ranking below average at the 26th percentile. For a worker relocating to this city, this means that the housing market is competitive, and they may need to act quickly to secure a home.

Office Economy

The professional talent pool in this metro area is relatively shallow, ranking below average at the 20th percentile. This means that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, it may be more suitable for businesses with industrial or logistics-oriented operations.

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area offers businesses a complex economic environment with both challenges and opportunities. While it has strong wage growth and an expanding housing supply, its weak labor demand and shrinking labor force create significant risks for businesses looking to hire and grow. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the limited availability of skilled talent, which may require businesses to invest in recruitment and training programs to build the skills they need.

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

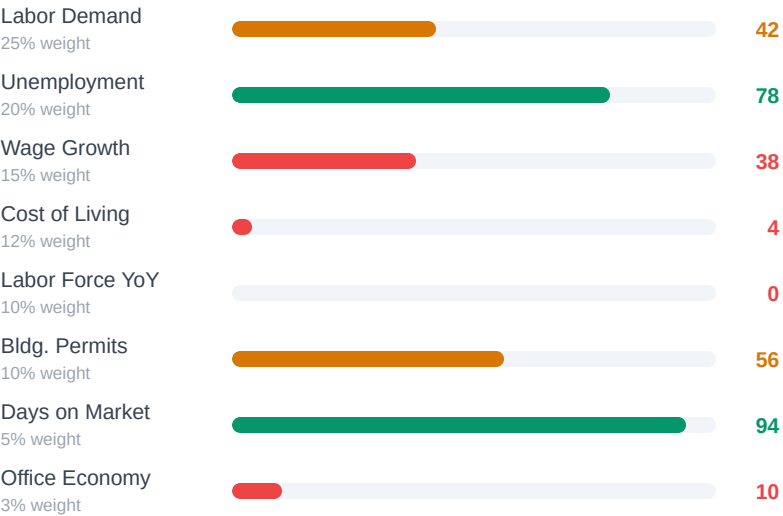
C+

POOR

42.9th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking at the 42.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor force growth rate of -4.53% YoY and its high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 6.82, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests significant challenges for businesses looking to expand or relocate in this area.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is -0.10% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating -0.605% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, with hours below trend during a period of job losses, suggesting a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This metric ranks near the median at the 42nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 4.00%, ranking above average at the 78th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with low unemployment. This means that businesses trying to hire in this area may face challenges in finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure. With a tight market, employers may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is +2.97%, ranking below average at the 38th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not as quickly as in other areas. As a result, businesses may face gradually increasing labor costs, but workers may not have as much bargaining power as they would in areas with faster wage growth.

Cost of Living

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has a cost of living ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile, with a PSF to wages ratio of 6.82, indicating that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The PSF is \$222/sqft, which has increased by 7.2% YoY, making it even more challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. This high cost of living may deter some businesses from relocating to the area, as they may need to offer higher salaries to compensate for the expensive living conditions.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is contracting at a rate of -4.53% YoY, indicating a shrinking labor pool and a structural headwind for hiring. This implies that businesses may face significant challenges in finding qualified workers, as the supply of labor is decreasing. As a result, companies may need to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain talent in this area.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is -0.59%, indicating a slight tightening of housing supply. This signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the demand for housing may outstrip the available supply. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact of limited housing options on their ability to attract and retain workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 37 days, with a year-over-year increase of 12.1%, ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, this may also signal a weakening demand for housing, which could have implications for the local economy.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 0.84, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies, and worst suited for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely on specialized office workers.

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area offers businesses a relatively tight labor market with low unemployment, but also presents significant challenges, including a high cost of living and a shrinking labor pool. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the limited availability of qualified workers, which may require businesses to invest in training and development programs or offer competitive salaries to attract and retain talent.

St. Louis

St. Louis

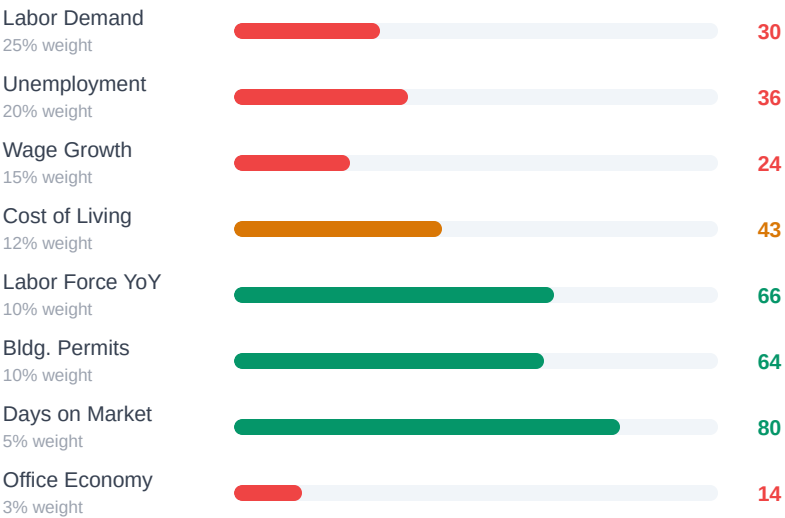
C+

POOR

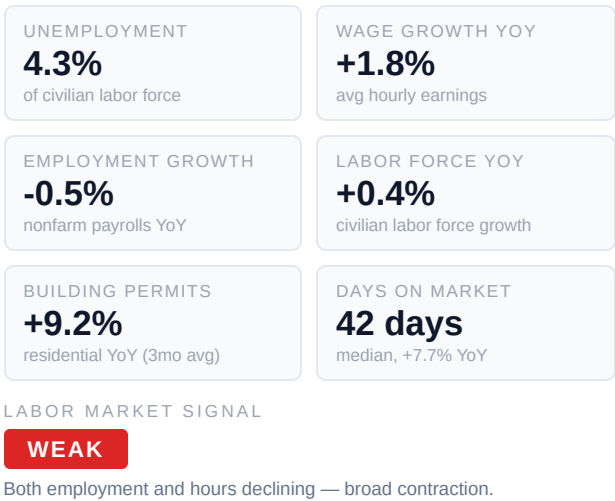
40.9th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The St. Louis metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 40.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 3.63, and its moderate cost of living, with a ratio of \$167/sqft to \$37.52/hr, ranking 43rd percentile. These metrics signal a city with sluggish job growth and moderate affordability.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in St. Louis is -0.48% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.025% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The negative employment growth rate suggests that payrolls are contracting, which may lead to a surplus of workers.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in St. Louis is 4.30%, ranking below average at the 36th percentile. This rate indicates that the market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the relatively low unemployment rate may still lead to some wage pressure, as workers have a moderate level of bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in St. Louis is +1.80%, which is below average, ranking at the 24th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slow pace. As a result, worker purchasing power is increasing, but at a relatively slow rate compared to other cities.

Cost of Living

St. Louis has a cost of living ratio of \$167/sqft to \$37.52/hr, ranking 43rd percentile, indicating that the city is moderately affordable. With a percentile rank in the middle tier, St. Louis offers a relatively neutral environment for talent attraction, neither requiring significant wage premiums nor offering a substantial advantage in affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in St. Louis is growing at a rate of +0.39% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking at the 66th percentile. This expansion in labor force supply suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in St. Louis is increasing by +9.19% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking at the 64th percentile. This growth in residential building permits signals that housing supply is expanding, which may lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market in St. Louis is 42 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.7%, ranking at the 80th percentile. This relatively slow market suggests that workers relocating to the city may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market, with more time to find a suitable home.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in St. Louis is relatively low, ranking at the 14th percentile. This suggests that the city has a shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The St. Louis metro area offers a business a moderately affordable environment with a growing labor force, but its sluggish job growth and limited professional talent pool pose significant risks. The single biggest constraint for a decision-maker is the city's below-average labor demand, which may limit the potential for business expansion and growth.

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

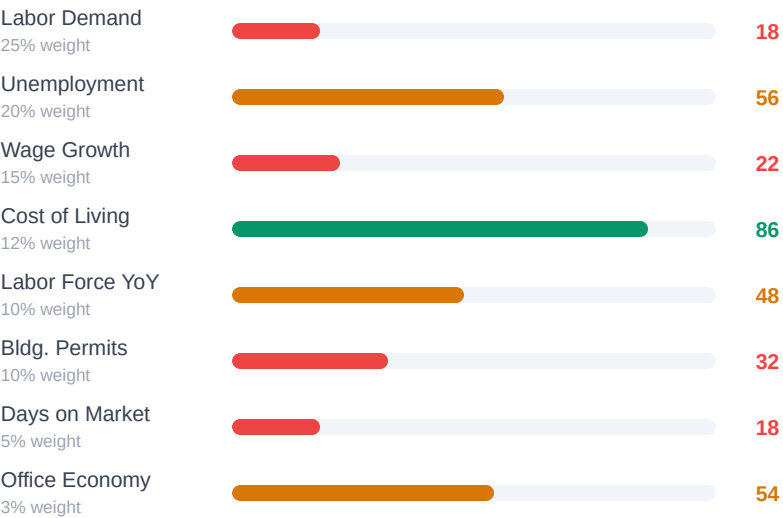
C+

POOR

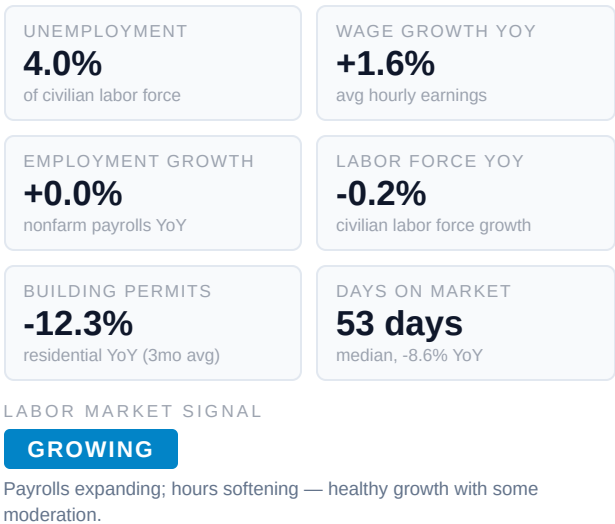
39.8th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 39.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier at 18th percentile, and its high affordability, with a cost of living score in the top tier at 86th percentile, driven by a PSF to earnings ratio of 5.40 (\$172/sqft vs \$31.85/hr). The combination of these metrics suggests a city with a relatively slow job market but an attractive cost of living.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is a mere 0.04% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -1.862% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a labor market that is not expanding genuinely. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, suggesting that the city's job market is not growing at a pace that would absorb new entrants or expansions. The low labor demand composite score of 2.86 further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels stands at 4.00%, placing it near the median at the 56th percentile. This rate suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, it is not so high as to indicate a severely weak local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Antonio-New Braunfels is +1.63%, which is below average, ranking at the 22nd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are not rising too quickly, but it also means that workers may not have strong bargaining power or significant increases in purchasing power.

Cost of Living

San Antonio-New Braunfels has a cost of living score in the top tier at 86th percentile, indicating that it is more affordable relative to its peers. With a PSF to earnings ratio of 5.40 (\$172/sqft vs \$31.85/hr) and a year-over-year decrease in PSF of -5.5%, this city offers a talent attraction advantage without needing significant wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Antonio-New Braunfels is growing at a rate of -0.16% year-over-year, indicating a slight contraction in the labor force supply. This negative growth rate suggests that the hiring capacity may face structural headwinds due to a shrinking labor pool.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -12.26%, indicating a tightening in housing supply. This decline in building permits signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, potentially leading to increased costs for housing and reduced attractiveness for relocating workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 53 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -8.6%. This relatively fast market, ranked in the bottom tier at 18th percentile, means that homes are selling quickly, which can make it competitive and challenging for relocating workers to find housing.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in San Antonio-New Braunfels is at the 54th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This city is suited for businesses that can thrive in a mixed economy but may not offer the same level of specialization as cities with a higher concentration of professional and office roles.

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area offers businesses an attractive cost of living and a labor market with some slack, but its slow labor demand growth and tightening housing supply are significant concerns. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the city's low labor demand and potential future affordability issues, which could impact the ability to attract and retain talent.

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

C+

POOR

39.7th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		26
25% weight		
Unemployment		24
20% weight		
Wage Growth		64
15% weight		
Cost of Living		61
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		72
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		4
10% weight		
Days on Market		64
5% weight		
Office Economy		22
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 4.3%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +4.9%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY -0.7%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth +0.8%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -37.0%	DAYS ON MARKET median, +10.3% YoY 32 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 39.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 3.26, and its above-average wage growth of 4.92% year-over-year. The combination of a -0.74% employment growth rate and -0.249% weekly hours deviation from trend suggests a contraction in labor demand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is -0.74% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.249% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. As a result, businesses may face a less competitive environment for talent acquisition.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 4.30%, ranking it below average at the 24th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the practical implication is that local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 4.92%, ranking it above average at the 64th percentile. This indicates fast wage growth, which may lead to rising labor costs for employers. On the other hand, workers in the city will have increased purchasing power, benefiting from the higher wages.

Cost of Living

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has a cost of living score ranking it at the 61st percentile, with a PSF of \$220/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.90. The city's cost of living is relatively affordable, with a PSF ratio of 5.96, which is above average. This means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is growing at a rate of 0.78% year-over-year, ranking it above average at the 72nd percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, providing businesses with a growing pool of potential employees. As a result, hiring capacity is likely to improve in the city.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has decreased by 36.97% year-over-year, ranking it at the bottom tier of the 4th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is currently 32 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.3%. This indicates a slower market, ranking it above average at the 64th percentile. For workers relocating to the city, this means a more accessible and less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has a professional and office worker share ranking it at the 22nd percentile, with a composite score of 1.60. This suggests a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making the city less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies.

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a growing labor force, but the single biggest risk or constraint is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation in the future. As a result, decision-makers should carefully consider the potential impact of this constraint on their business operations and talent attraction strategies. Overall, the city's below-average labor demand and limited office economy talent pool also pose challenges for businesses looking to establish or expand operations in the area.

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

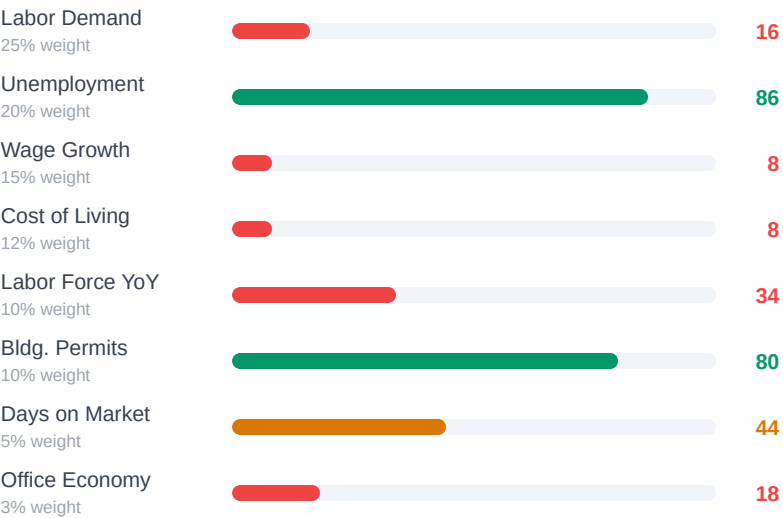
C

VERY POOR

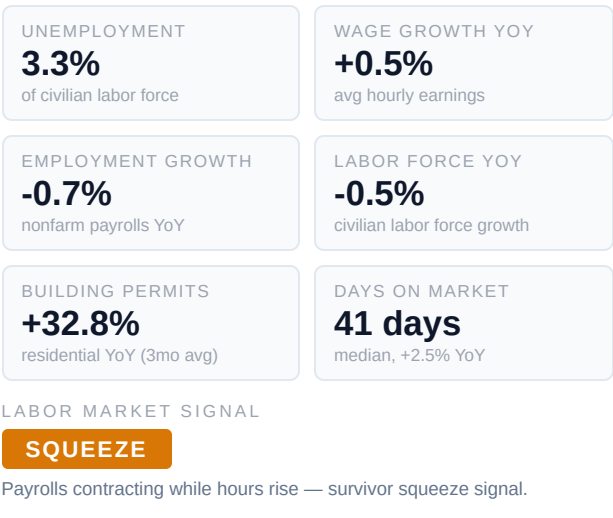
37.5th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 37.5th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 2.67, indicating a struggling job market. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand and stagnant wage growth, with employment growth at -0.72% year-over-year and wage growth at +0.46% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Indianapolis is -0.72% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.621%, signaling a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This combination indicates a contraction in genuine demand expansion, as hours are above trend during a period of job losses. The labor demand composite score of 2.67 falls in the bottom tier, at the 16th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Indianapolis is 3.30%, which is relatively low, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This tight labor market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with more wage pressure and competition for skilled workers. As a result, companies may need to offer higher salaries or benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Indianapolis is +0.46%, which is stagnant and falls in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are relatively flat, but worker purchasing power is weak. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may have limited disposable income to drive local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Indianapolis has a cost of living score that falls in the bottom tier, at the 8th percentile, with a PSF of \$168/sqft and an earnings ratio of \$32.75/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.13. The city is relatively expensive, with PSF increasing by 5.7% year-over-year, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. This may be a disadvantage for businesses looking to relocate or expand in the area.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Indianapolis is contracting at a rate of -0.50% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 34th percentile. This decline in labor force supply implies that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring, with a shrinking pool of potential workers. As a result, companies may need to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain talent.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Indianapolis is increasing by 32.81% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 80th percentile. This expansion in housing supply signals that developer confidence is rising, and future affordability and workforce accommodation may improve. As a result, businesses may find it easier to attract and retain workers in the area, with a more affordable and expanding housing market.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Indianapolis is 41 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.5%, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This relatively fast market means that workers relocating to the city may face competition for housing, but the market is not extremely competitive. As a result, businesses may need to provide relocation assistance or support to help workers find housing in the area.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Indianapolis is relatively low, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This suggests that the city has a limited talent pool for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, making it less suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge-economy workers. However, the city may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses that require a different type of workforce.

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area offers businesses a relatively low unemployment rate and expanding housing supply, but the city's struggling job market, stagnant wage growth, and limited professional talent pool pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand and limited workforce supply, which may hinder businesses' ability to attract and retain top talent, making it essential to carefully consider these factors when making location decisions.

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

C

VERY POOR

36.5th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		36
Unemployment 20% weight		26
Wage Growth 15% weight		48
Cost of Living 12% weight		14
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		98
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		16
Days on Market 5% weight		4
Office Economy 3% weight		60

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 3.9%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +3.7%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY -0.4%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth +2.9%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -22.8%	DAYS ON MARKET median, 0.0% YoY 25 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.5th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score reflecting a mix of weak labor demand and high cost of living. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand composite score of 3.73, which combines a -0.41% employment growth rate and a -0.399% weekly hours deviation from trend, as well as its expensive cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 10.96. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is -0.41% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.399% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, with hours below trend during a period of job losses, suggesting a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This metric ranks below average, at the 36th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 3.90%, which is below average, ranking at the 26th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward wage pressure. As a result, companies may face challenges in finding and retaining talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is +3.66%, which is near the median, ranking at the 48th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a manageable pace, while worker purchasing power is also increasing. This balance may attract businesses looking for a stable labor market.

Cost of Living

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has a cost of living score that ranks at the 14th percentile, with a PSF to wages ratio of 10.96, and a year-over-year increase of +0.4% in PSF. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The high cost of living may deter some companies from relocating to this area.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is growing at a rate of +2.87% year-over-year, which is a top-tier growth rate, ranking at the 98th percentile. This expansion in labor supply suggests that the city has a growing workforce, making it easier for businesses to find and hire new employees. This metric is a significant advantage for companies looking to expand their operations.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Boston-Cambridge-Newton has decreased by -22.81% year-over-year, which is a bottom-tier performance, ranking at the 16th percentile. This decline in building permits signals a tightening of housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 25 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranking at the 4th percentile. This indicates a highly competitive market, where homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing. This metric suggests that businesses may need to offer relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent.

Office Economy

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking at the 60th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area offers businesses a highly skilled and growing labor force, but also presents significant challenges, including a high cost of living and a competitive housing market. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's expensive cost of living, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially increasing labor costs and affecting profitability.

Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

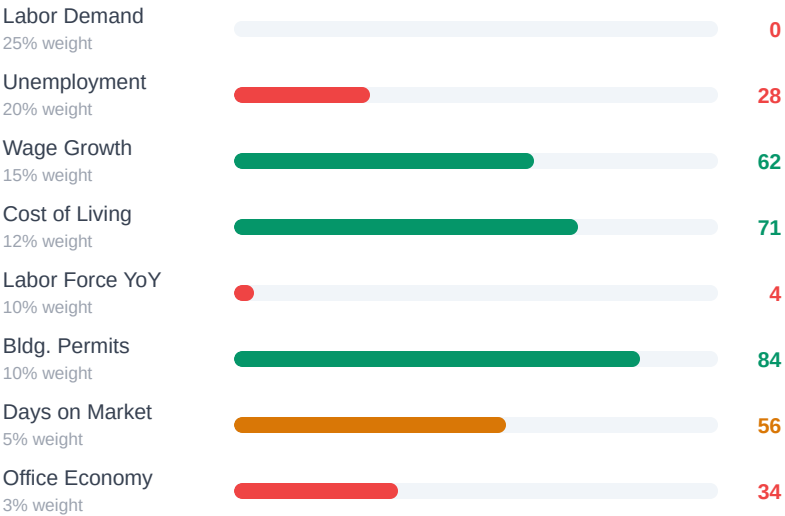
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VERY POOR

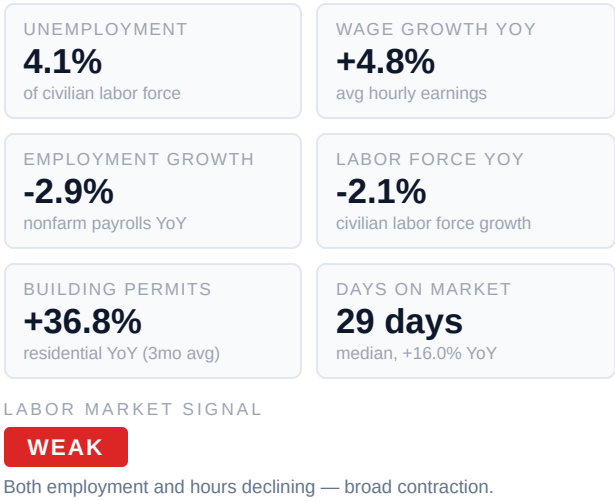
36.1th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.1th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score largely defined by its weak labor demand and labor force growth, at 0th and 4th percentiles, respectively. The labor demand composite score of 1.50, driven by a -2.86% employment growth rate and -0.505% weekly hours deviation, signals a contraction in labor demand. This combination of metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or hire in the area.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is -2.86% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.505% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as hours are below trend during a period of job losses, suggesting a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This metric is a significant concern for businesses relying on a strong labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 4.10%, ranking at the 28th percentile, indicating a below-average but not extremely tight labor market. While there is some slack in the market, the relatively low unemployment rate still suggests that businesses may face some challenges in hiring, particularly for specialized roles. However, the market is not as competitive as those with even lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is +4.85%, ranking at the 62nd percentile, indicating above-average wage growth. This fast wage growth suggests rising labor costs for employers but also strong worker purchasing power, which can be beneficial for businesses relying on local consumer demand. As wages continue to rise, businesses may need to adjust their pricing strategies to maintain profitability.

Cost of Living

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has a cost of living score ranking at the 71st percentile, with a PSF of \$310/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$44.71, resulting in a ratio of 6.93. The fact that PSF is falling -3.7% year-over-year relative to wages makes the city more affordable. This high percentile rank indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage, as businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is growing at a rate of -2.11% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This negative growth rate suggests a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is shrinking. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in workforce development programs to address this constraint.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is increasing by +36.76% year-over-year, ranking at the 84th percentile. This significant increase in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. As housing supply expands, the city may become more attractive to workers and businesses alike.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 29 days, with a year-over-year increase of +16.0%, ranking at the 56th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced market, neither extremely competitive nor slow. For workers relocating to the city, this suggests a moderately accessible housing market, although the rising days on market may signal a normalization of the market rather than a significant slowdown.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria ranks at the 34th percentile, indicating a below-average depth of professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area offers a relatively affordable cost of living and above-average wage growth, which can be beneficial for businesses and workers alike. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the weak labor demand and contracting labor force, which may limit hiring capacity and require significant investment in workforce development or attraction strategies.

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

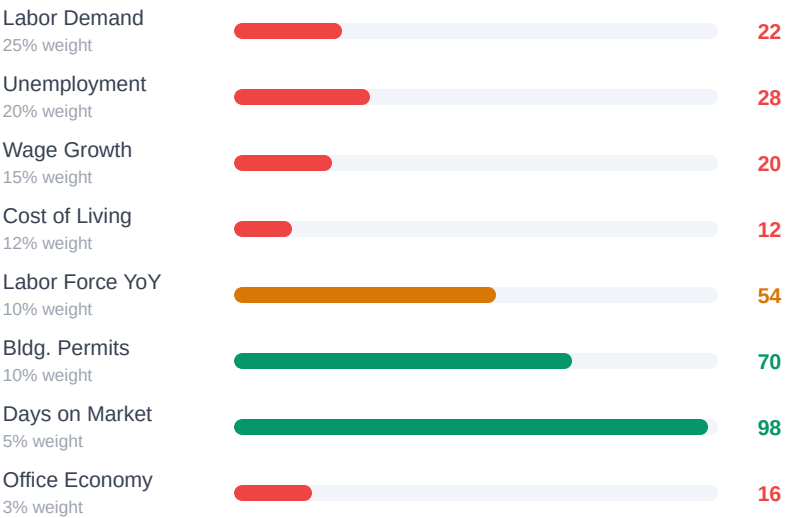
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VERY POOR

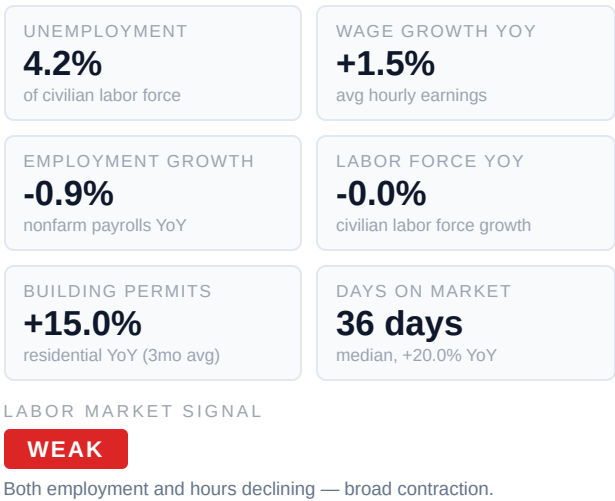
33.3th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 33.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 3.03, indicating a below-average performance. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand and high cost of living, with a cost of living ratio of 6.29, resulting from \$227/sqft and \$36.11/hr, and ranking in the 12th percentile. This suggests that the city's economy is experiencing a contraction in labor demand, which is a significant concern for businesses looking to locate here.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is -0.91% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.049% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as both employment growth and hours worked are below trend. As a result, businesses may face challenges in finding skilled workers, but may also have an easier time managing labor costs.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 4.20%, which is below average, ranking in the 28th percentile. This indicates that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the relatively low unemployment rate also suggests that wage pressure may be moderate, as workers have some bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is +1.49%, which is below average, ranking in the 20th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slow pace. As a result, worker purchasing power is increasing, but at a moderate rate, which may have a positive impact on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Milwaukee-Waukesha has a cost of living ratio of 6.29, resulting from \$227/sqft and \$36.11/hr, and ranking in the 12th percentile, indicating that the city is relatively expensive. This means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the high cost of living may be a deterrent for some workers. However, the city's relatively low cost of living compared to other major metros may still make it an attractive option for some businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Milwaukee-Waukesha is growing at a rate of -0.01% year-over-year, which is near the median. This indicates that the labor force supply is essentially stable, neither expanding nor contracting significantly. As a result, businesses may face moderate

challenges in finding skilled workers, but the stable labor force supply may also provide some stability for employers.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Milwaukee-Waukesha is increasing by +15.03% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking in the 70th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. As a result, businesses may find it easier to attract and retain workers, as the increasing housing supply may reduce the cost of living.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of +20.0%, ranking in the 98th percentile. This indicates that the housing market is slowing down, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. As a result, businesses may find it easier to attract workers, as the slower housing market may provide more options for relocating employees.

Office Economy

Milwaukee-Waukesha has a professional and office worker share of 1.16, ranking in the 16th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This suggests that the city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics companies. However, the city may not be the best fit for tech, finance, or consulting businesses that require a highly specialized workforce.

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area offers businesses a relatively stable labor force supply and an expanding housing market, which may improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. However, the city's high cost of living and low labor demand are significant concerns, and businesses should carefully consider these factors when making a location decision. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the high cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract talent, and the low labor demand, which may limit the availability of skilled workers.

Richmond

Richmond

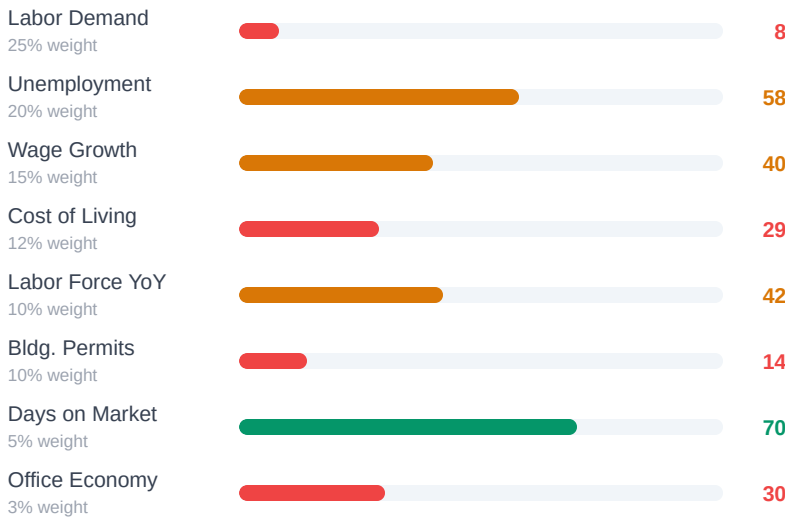
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VERY POOR

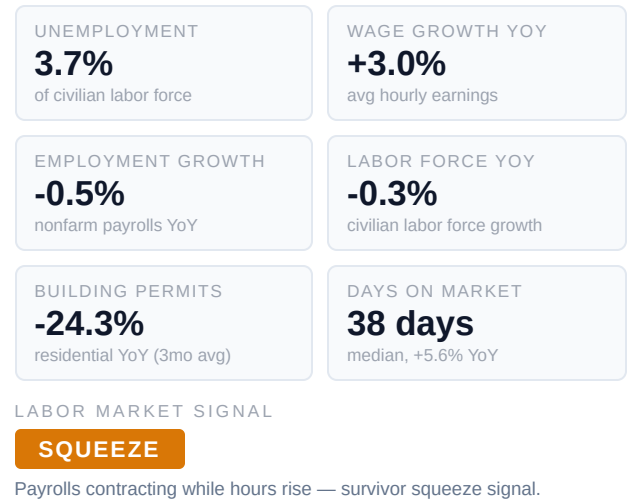
33.0th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Richmond metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 33rd out of 50 US metros, with a composite score defined largely by its weak labor demand and declining building permits. The labor demand composite score of 2.22, combining a -0.54% employment growth rate and a +1.323% weekly hours deviation, signals a contraction in job opportunities. This is further exacerbated by a significant decline in building permits, down 24.31% year-over-year.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Richmond is -0.54% year-over-year, while weekly hours are running 1.323% above the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 2.22 falls in the bottom tier, at the 8th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Richmond is 3.70%, ranking at the 58th percentile, indicating a near-median level of slack in the labor market. This suggests that while the market is not extremely tight, it is also not overly loose, with some competition for jobs but not extreme wage pressure. For a business trying to hire, this means a moderate level of difficulty in finding qualified candidates.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Richmond is +3.03% year-over-year, ranking at the 40th percentile, indicating a moderate pace of wage increases. This implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely rapidly, while worker purchasing power is increasing at a steady rate. The wage growth rate is neither extremely fast nor stagnant, suggesting a relatively stable labor cost environment.

Cost of Living

Richmond has a cost of living score of 29th percentile, with a PSF of \$233/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.20, resulting in a ratio of 6.44. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, with a rising PSF trend, making it less attractive for talent without wage premiums. The below-average affordability score suggests that businesses may need to offer higher wages to compensate for the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Richmond is shrinking at a rate of -0.33% year-over-year, ranking at the 42nd percentile. This contraction in the labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find qualified candidates. The declining labor force growth rate suggests that the city's workforce is not expanding to meet demand.

Building Permits

Building permits in Richmond are down 24.31% year-over-year, indicating a significant tightening of the housing supply. This decline in permits signals a potential future affordability crisis and workforce accommodation challenges, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. The sharp decline in permits suggests that the city's housing market may become increasingly competitive.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Richmond is 38 days, with a year-over-year increase of 5.6%, ranking at the 70th percentile. This suggests a relatively slow market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. The rising days on market indicates a normalization of the housing market, rather than a demand-driven surge.

Office Economy

Richmond's office economy is relatively weak, with a professional and office worker share ranking at the 30th percentile. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not particularly deep in specialized roles, making it less suited for tech, finance, or consulting businesses. However, the city may be more attractive for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Richmond metro area offers a business a relatively stable labor cost environment and a moderate level of difficulty in hiring, but the single biggest risk or constraint is the declining labor force and tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability and workforce accommodation challenges. The city's weak labor demand and declining building permits are significant concerns for businesses considering relocation or expansion. Overall, Richmond's economic character is defined by its contraction in job opportunities and declining housing supply, making it a challenging location for businesses to thrive.

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

C

VERY POOR

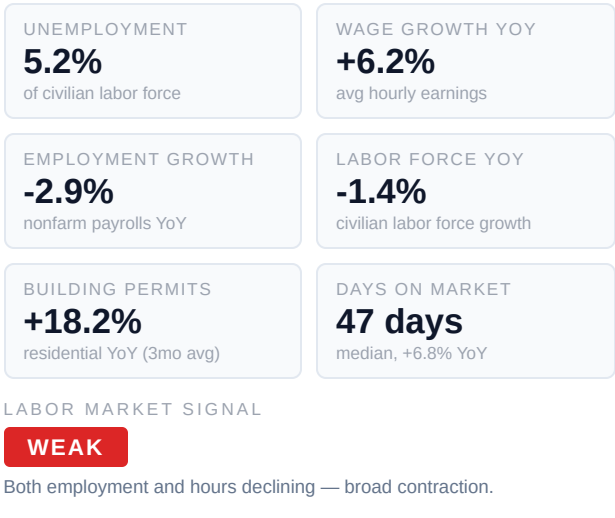
32.4th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 32.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score largely defined by its weak labor demand and high wage growth. The labor demand composite score of 1.50, combining a -2.85% employment growth rate and a -0.220% weekly hours deviation from trend, signals a contraction in labor demand. This, coupled with a strong 6.21% year-over-year wage growth, suggests a complex economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is -2.85%, indicating a decline in job additions, while the weekly hours deviation from trend is -0.220%, signaling hours are running below the 12-month baseline. This combination suggests a labor demand contraction rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The negative employment growth rate is a significant concern for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 5.20%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile, indicating a relatively high level of unemployment compared to other metros. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire, but it also implies weaker local consumer demand. Businesses may find it relatively easier to staff their operations, but the local economy's overall health could be a concern.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 6.21%, placing it in the 78th percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This rapid increase in wages suggests rising labor costs for employers but also implies strong worker purchasing power. Businesses should be prepared for higher labor costs, but the local workforce will have increased disposable income, potentially benefiting consumer-facing industries.

Cost of Living

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has a cost of living score that ranks in the 67th percentile, with a PSF of \$311/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$42.24/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.36. The PSF is falling by 2.8% year-over-year, contributing to the city's relative affordability. This makes the city more attractive for talent without requiring significant wage premiums, as the cost of living is more manageable compared to peer cities.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is growing at a rate of -1.39% year-over-year, indicating a contraction in the labor force supply. This negative growth rate suggests that the workforce is shrinking, posing a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. Businesses may face challenges in finding and retaining talent due to the declining labor pool.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has increased by 18.23% year-over-year, signaling an expansion in housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that developer confidence is strong, and future housing supply is expected to increase, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. This is a positive sign for businesses concerned about the ability of their employees to find affordable housing.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 47 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.8%. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell. For workers relocating to the city, this could mean a more accessible and less competitive housing market, allowing them more time to find suitable housing.

Office Economy

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has an office economy score ranking in the 8th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 0.68. This suggests a relatively shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors, making the city less suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, or HQ operations that rely heavily on such talent. However, it might be more suitable for industries with different workforce requirements.

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area offers a complex mix of high wage growth and a contracting labor force, making it challenging for businesses to navigate. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor pool, which could significantly impact hiring capacity and business expansion plans. Despite some positive indicators like increasing building permits and a relatively affordable cost of living, the overall economic character of the city, defined by its weak labor demand and labor force contraction, poses significant challenges for businesses considering location decisions.

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

C-

CRITICAL

31.5th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		20
Unemployment 20% weight		4
Wage Growth 15% weight		30
Cost of Living 12% weight		45
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		76
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		34
Days on Market 5% weight		68
Office Economy 3% weight		48

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 5.3%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +2.3%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY -0.9%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth +0.9%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -12.0%	DAYS ON MARKET median, +5.4% YoY 39 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 31.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 3.00 ranking it in the 20th percentile, and its high unemployment rate of 5.30%, which ranks it in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is -0.93% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.632% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job growth and hours worked. This suggests that businesses may face a relatively easy time hiring, but may also struggle with a lack of skilled workers.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 5.30%, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This indicates a relatively slack labor market, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, this also suggests that local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is +2.32%, ranking it in the 30th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a relatively slow pace. This also means that worker purchasing power is increasing, but not at a rapid rate.

Cost of Living

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has a cost of living score ranking it in the 45th percentile, with a PSF of \$177/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$37.15/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.76. This near-median ranking suggests that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. This affordability can be a talent attraction advantage for businesses, as workers may not require significant wage premiums to relocate.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is growing at a rate of +0.92% year-over-year, ranking it in the 76th percentile. This expanding labor force supply suggests that businesses have a growing pool of potential workers to hire from, making it easier to find skilled talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has decreased by -12.03% year-over-year, ranking it in the 34th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is currently 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.4%. This relatively slow market, ranking in the 68th percentile, suggests that workers relocating to the city may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn ranks in the 48th percentile, indicating a relatively deep talent pool. This suggests that the city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but may not be as suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and an expanding labor force, but also poses significant challenges due to its low labor demand and high unemployment rate. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for a lack of skilled workers and decreasing affordability in the future, making it essential to carefully consider these factors when evaluating the city as a potential location.

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

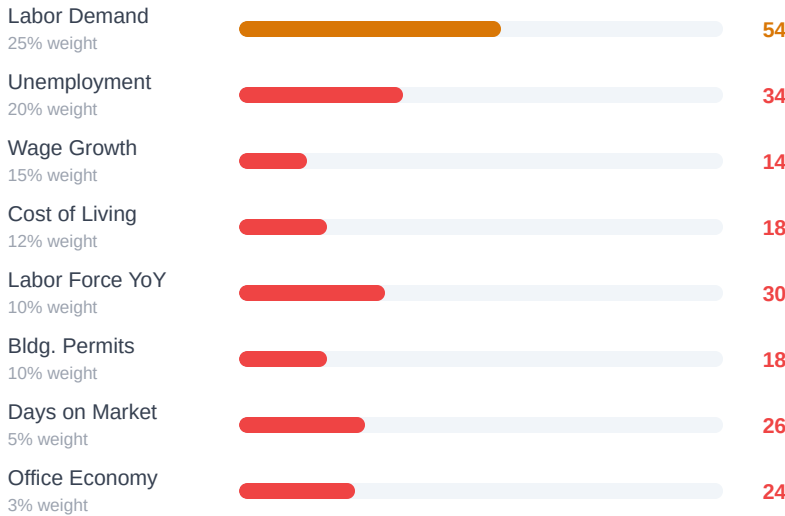
C-

CRITICAL

31.4th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.7%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.1%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.4%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.6%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-21.4%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

38 days

median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 31.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low wage growth, at +1.14% year-over-year, and its declining labor force growth, at -0.59% year-over-year. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to attract and retain talent.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +0.44% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.101% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate labor demand expansion, with some genuine demand for jobs but not enough to drive significant hours growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.81 ranks near the median at 54th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 4.70%, ranking below average at 34th percentile. This indicates a moderate level of slack in the labor market, making it somewhat easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the relatively high unemployment rate also suggests weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +1.14%, ranking in the bottom tier at 14th percentile. This slow wage growth signals a relatively flat cost environment for employers, but it also means weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. As a result, businesses may not face significant labor cost pressures, but they may also struggle to attract top talent.

Cost of Living

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has a cost of living score ranking in the bottom tier at 18th percentile, with a PSF of \$344/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$38.20/hr, resulting in a ratio of 9.01. The city's cost of living is relatively expensive, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling -0.3% year-over-year is a positive sign, but the overall affordability score remains low.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is contracting at -0.59% year-over-year, ranking below average at 30th percentile. This decline in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find the talent they need. As a result, companies may need to invest more in recruitment and training to attract and retain workers.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is declining at -21.43% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at 18th percentile. This sharp decline in permits signals a tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability challenges and make it harder for workers to relocate to the area. As a result, businesses may face increased competition for talent and higher labor costs.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 38 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranking below average at 26th percentile. This relatively fast market means that homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing. However, the stable days on market suggests a relatively balanced market, without significant signs of demand erosion.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is relatively low, ranking below average at 24th percentile. This suggests a less deep talent pool for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, or HQ sectors, making the city less suited for these types of companies. However, the city may be more attractive to industrial or logistics businesses that require a different type of workforce.

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area offers businesses a relatively flat cost environment and moderate labor market slack, but it also poses significant challenges in terms of talent attraction and retention due to slow wage growth and a declining labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited labor force growth, which may require businesses to invest more in recruitment and training to find the talent they need.

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

C-

CRITICAL

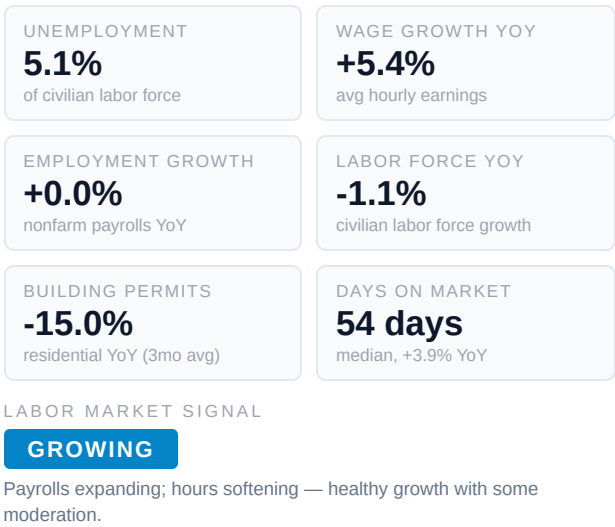
30.8th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 30.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 3.03, and its above-average wage growth of 5.40% year-over-year. The labor demand and wage growth metrics are critical in understanding the city's current economic landscape, with the 24th percentile labor demand score and 68th percentile wage growth rate indicating a complex environment for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 0.01% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -1.281% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion, as the minimal job growth is accompanied by a decrease in hours worked. This suggests that the city's labor market is not experiencing strong growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 5.10%, which is below average, ranking 22nd percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire in this city. As a result, businesses may face some competition for talent, but it is still possible to find qualified workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 5.40%, which is above average, ranking 68th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but it also means that workers have strong purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to attract and retain talent in this city.

Cost of Living

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a cost of living score ranking 37th percentile, with a PSF of \$337/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$35.23/hr, resulting in a ratio of 9.57. The city's PSF is falling -2.3% year-over-year, which is a key driver of its relatively affordable score. This means that the city has a moderate talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require significant wage premiums to afford the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is contracting at a rate of -1.10% year-over-year, ranking 14th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is shrinking, which may create a structural headwind for hiring in the city. As a result, businesses may

need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in workforce development programs.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is decreasing by -15.03% year-over-year, ranking 26th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact of housing costs on their employees' quality of life.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 54 days, with a year-over-year increase of 3.9%. This indicates a relatively slow market, ranking 36th percentile. For workers relocating to this city, the slower market may make it easier to find a home, but it also suggests that the city's housing market is not as competitive as others.

Office Economy

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a very shallow professional talent pool, ranking 0th percentile in terms of office and professional worker share. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics companies. On the other hand, it may not be the best fit for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely on specialized office workers.

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area offers businesses a unique combination of above-average wage growth and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the city's below-average labor demand, shrinking labor force, and tightening housing supply are significant risks that decision-makers should factor into their location decisions, as they may impact the city's ability to attract and retain talent in the long term.

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

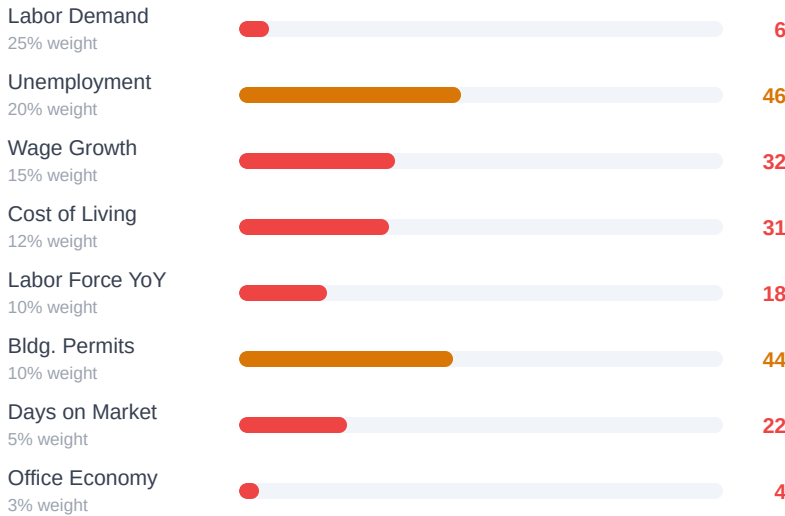
C-

CRITICAL

26.6th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.4%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+2.3%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.8%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.9%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-6.1%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

38 days

median, -2.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 26.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand and labor force growth, with employment growth at -0.80% year-over-year and labor force growth at -0.94% year-over-year. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of -0.80% and weekly hours deviation of +1.270% from the city's own trend suggest a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 1.91 ranks in the bottom tier at 6th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.40% ranks near the median at 46th percentile, indicating a moderate level of slack in the labor market. This means that businesses may have a relatively easier time hiring, but may not face significant wage pressure. However, the unemployment rate is not low enough to suggest a highly competitive market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +2.34% ranks below average at 32nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate, and worker purchasing power is increasing. However, the wage growth rate is not high enough to suggest a highly competitive labor market.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Louisville-Jefferson County is below average, with a percentile rank of 31st, due to a PSF of \$180/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$31.28/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.75. However, the PSF is rising at +1.1% year-over-year, which may erode affordability over time. This means that the city has a talent attraction advantage without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force growth rate of -0.94% year-over-year indicates that the supply of workers is contracting. This implies a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find and attract talent. The labor force growth rate ranks in the bottom tier at 18th percentile.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -6.07%, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This signals a potential supply squeeze building ahead, which may erode future affordability and workforce accommodation. The building permits growth rate ranks near the median at 44th percentile.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 38 days, with a year-over-year direction of -2.6%, indicating a relatively fast market. This means that homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The days on market ranks below average at 22nd percentile.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 0.44, ranking in the bottom tier at 4th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area offers businesses a moderate cost of living and a relatively low unemployment rate, but the biggest risk or constraint is the contracting labor force and tightening housing supply. Decision-makers should factor in the potential challenges of finding and attracting talent, as well as the erosion of affordability over time, when considering this city as a location for their business.

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

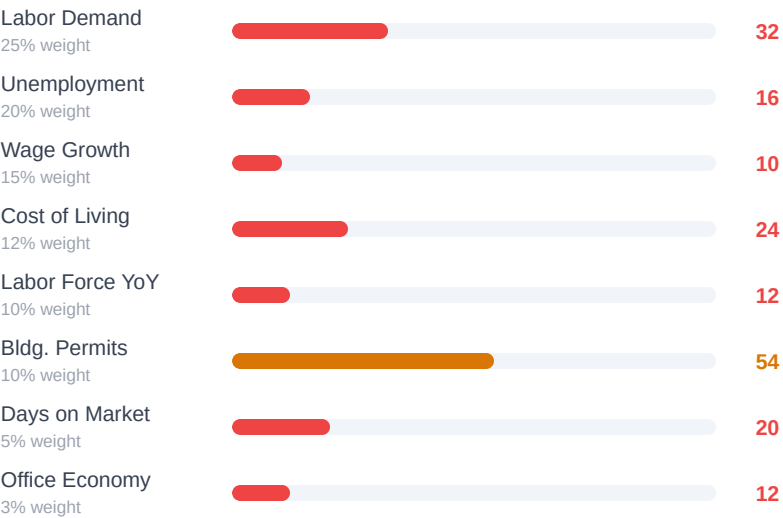
D

EMERGENCY

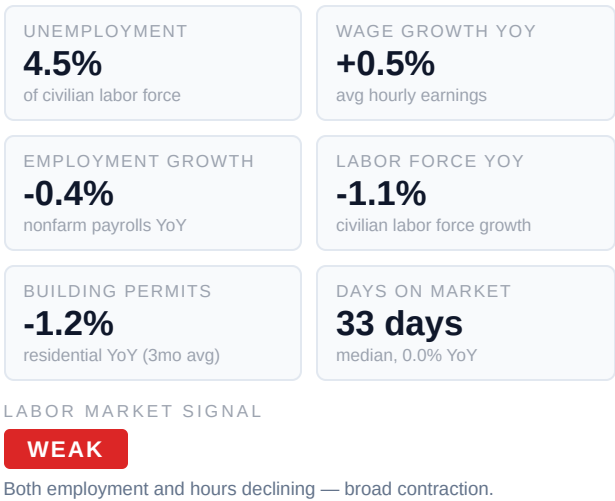
23.6th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking 23.6th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its labor demand and unemployment metrics, which are both below average. The labor demand composite score is 3.68, placing it in the 32nd percentile, while the unemployment rate is 4.50%, ranking in the 16th percentile. These numbers suggest a challenging economic environment, with the labor market being a key concern.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is -0.44% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.099% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a genuine demand contraction, rather than a survivor squeeze, as both jobs and hours are declining. This suggests that businesses may not face intense competition for workers, but rather a shrinking pool of potential employees.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 4.50%, which is relatively high, ranking in the 16th percentile. This indicates that the labor market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, this also means that local consumer demand may be weaker, potentially impacting businesses that rely on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +0.51%, which is relatively slow, ranking in the 10th percentile. This suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. As a result, businesses may not face strong pressure to increase wages, but workers may also have limited disposable income to spend on goods and services.

Cost of Living

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has a cost of living score that places it in the 24th percentile, with a PSF of \$215/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$39.19/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.49. The city's PSF is falling -0.9% year-over-year, which is a positive sign for affordability. This suggests that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage, as businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is shrinking at a rate of -1.13% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This suggests that the city's hiring capacity may be limited, making it challenging for businesses to find and attract new workers. As a

result, businesses may need to invest in retention and training programs to maintain their workforce.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is declining at a rate of -1.17% year-over-year, which is near the median. This suggests that the city's housing supply is not expanding rapidly, which could lead to future affordability and workforce accommodation challenges. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact of limited housing options on their ability to attract and retain workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 33 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%. This suggests that the housing market is relatively slow, ranking in the 20th percentile. For workers relocating to the city, this means that they may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market, which could be an advantage.

Office Economy

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has a professional and office worker share of 0.90, ranking in the 12th percentile. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not particularly deep in professional and office sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a high concentration of tech, finance, or consulting talent. However, the city may be more suitable for businesses with industrial or logistics-dominated economies.

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a slower housing market, which could be advantages for talent attraction and retention. However, the city's labor market is a significant concern, with a shrinking labor pool and slow wage growth, which could limit hiring capacity and impact local consumer demand. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the challenging labor market, which may require significant investment in retention and training programs to maintain a skilled workforce.

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

D

EMERGENCY

18.9th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		12
Unemployment 20% weight		2
Wage Growth 15% weight		16
Cost of Living 12% weight		35
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		52
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		6
Days on Market 5% weight		32
Office Economy 3% weight		50

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 4.7%	WAGE GROWTH YOY +1.2% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY -0.4%	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.1% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -34.1%	DAYS ON MARKET 58 days median, +1.8% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL SQUEEZE Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Jacksonville has an overall grade of D, ranking in the 18.9th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 2.55, placing it in the bottom tier. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand and high unemployment rate, with employment growth at -0.42% year-over-year and an unemployment rate of 4.70%. These metrics signal significant challenges for businesses looking to expand or relocate in the area.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Jacksonville is -0.42% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of +1.167% above its own trend. This signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 2.55 is in the bottom tier, indicating a weak job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Jacksonville is 4.70%, placing it in the bottom tier. This indicates a relatively loose labor market, with some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, this also suggests weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses reliant on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Jacksonville is +1.23%, which is relatively slow. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. This could make it easier for businesses to manage labor costs, but may also limit worker demand for goods and services.

Cost of Living

Jacksonville has a cost of living score with a PSF of \$218/sqft, which is decreasing by -2.2% year-over-year, compared to average hourly earnings of \$36.76/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.93. With a percentile rank of 35th, the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. This makes it easier for businesses to attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Jacksonville is growing at a rate of -0.05% year-over-year, indicating a slight contraction in the labor pool. This implies that the supply of workers is not expanding, which could create structural headwinds for hiring and business growth.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Jacksonville has decreased by -34.14% year-over-year, indicating a significant tightening of the housing supply. This suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping

pace with demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Jacksonville is 58 days, with a year-over-year increase of +1.8%. This indicates a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this also suggests that the housing market may be normalizing, rather than being highly competitive.

Office Economy

Jacksonville has an office economy score with a percentile rank of 50th, indicating a relatively deep professional talent pool. This makes the city suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but less suited for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The city of Jacksonville presents a challenging environment for businesses, with low labor demand and high unemployment. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the limited supply of workers and the tightening housing market, which could create significant headwinds for growth and expansion. Despite some advantages in terms of affordability, the overall economic character of the city suggests that businesses may need to carefully consider these challenges before making a location decision.